PIP / YEARS LATER

I'm Pip Arden, the cadet from the capsule. Years later, I checked our flight logs and asked the others. Here's how our first rescue really went.

CAPTAIN BEAM / FLEETVISION

BEAM

BEAM

BEAM

BEAM

PIP / YEARS LATER

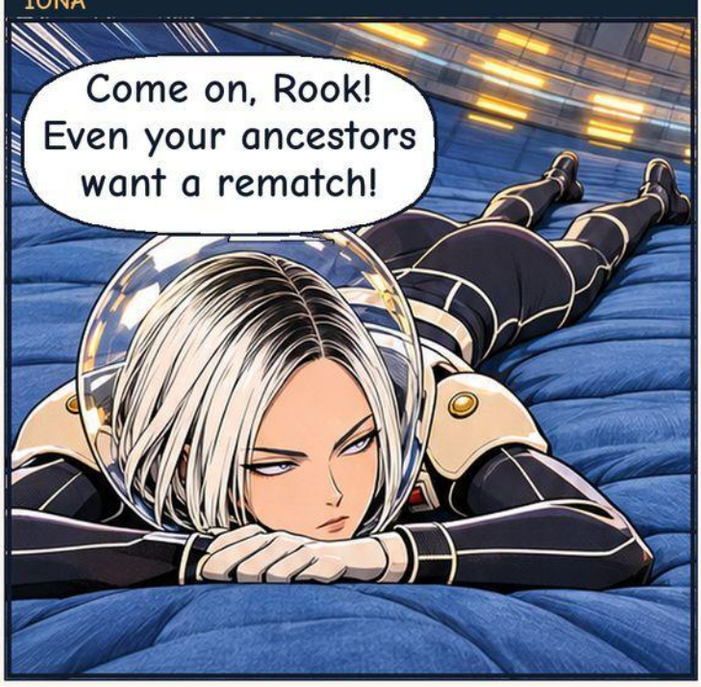
That's a centrifuge: a spinning room that makes Mars legs practise Earth's much heavier pull.

ROOK SEN / PILOT

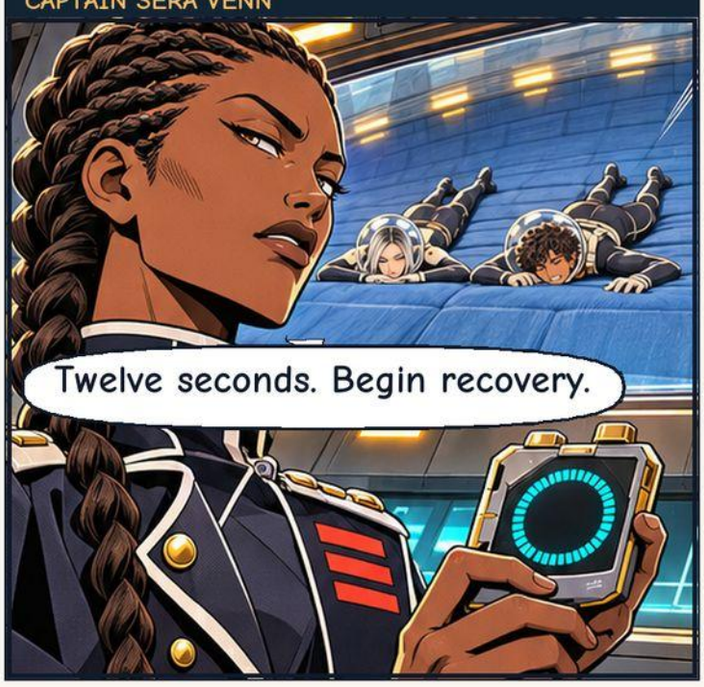
IONA VALE / BOARDING CADET

ROOK

IONA



CAPTAIN SERA VENN

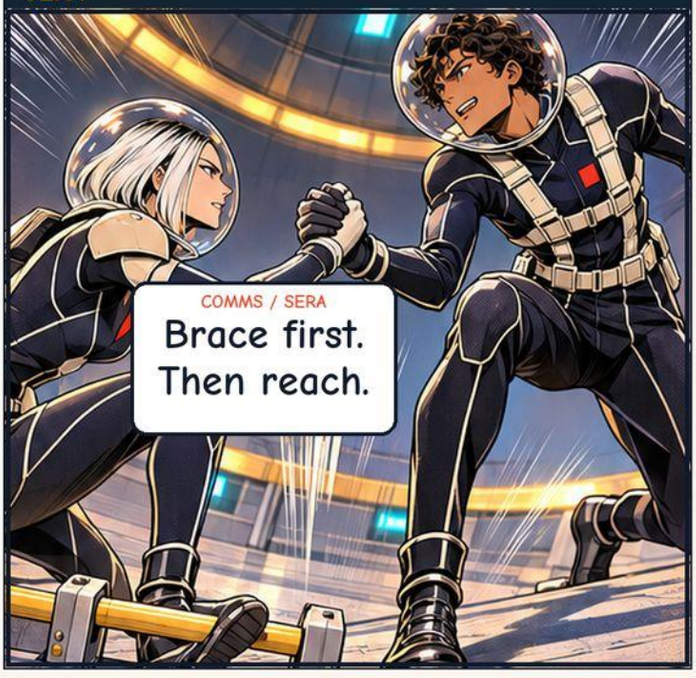


ROOK
Is surrendering to the floor considered treason, Captain?
SERA
Only if you tell it where we keep the biscuits.
IONA
Elbow. Knee. Breathe. Come on, Rook! Fight the floor!
BEAM
FV
Observe the tactical hug! A bold embrace of hostile terrain!
IONA
Ha! Beat you to kneeling. Keep up, poster boy!

ROOK

IONA

SERA

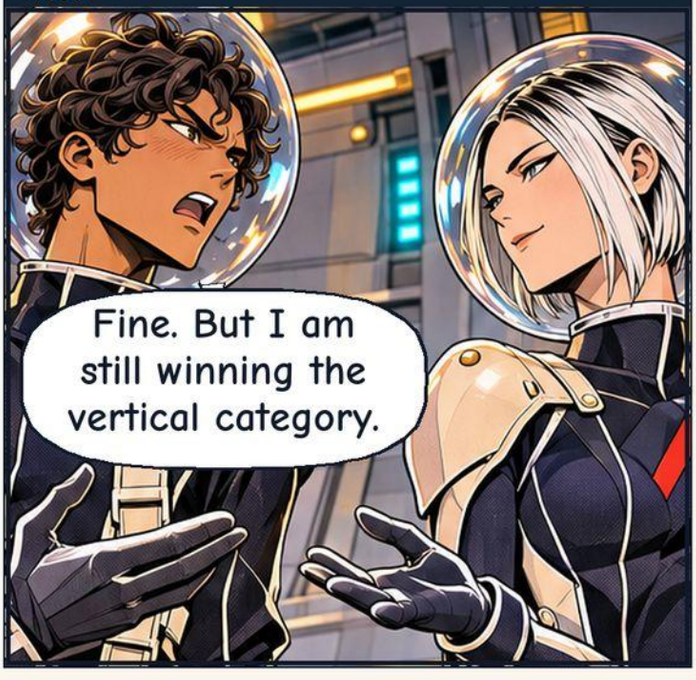


PIP / YEARS LATER

Iona boarded things. Rook flew them. Their captain's job was getting both of them home.

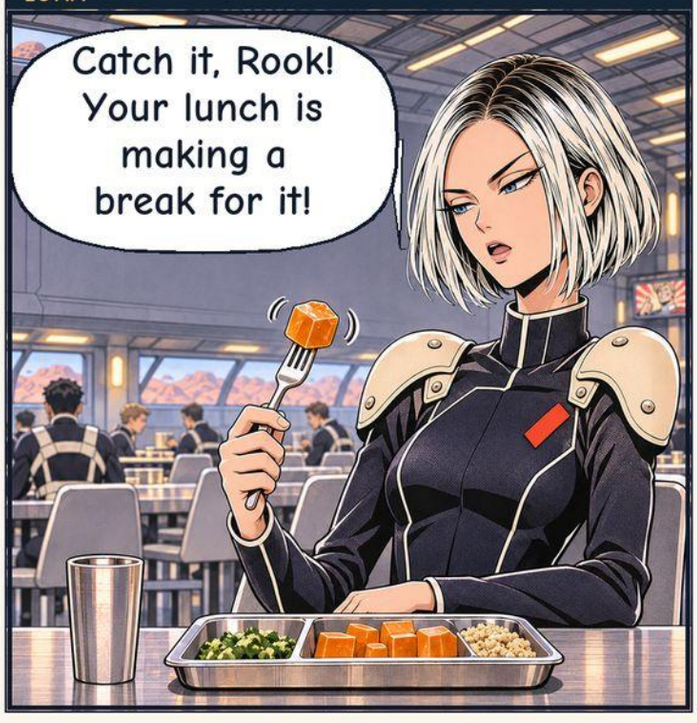
SERA

ROOK



ROOK

IONA



TAVI ORR / ENGINEER

PIP / YEARS LATER

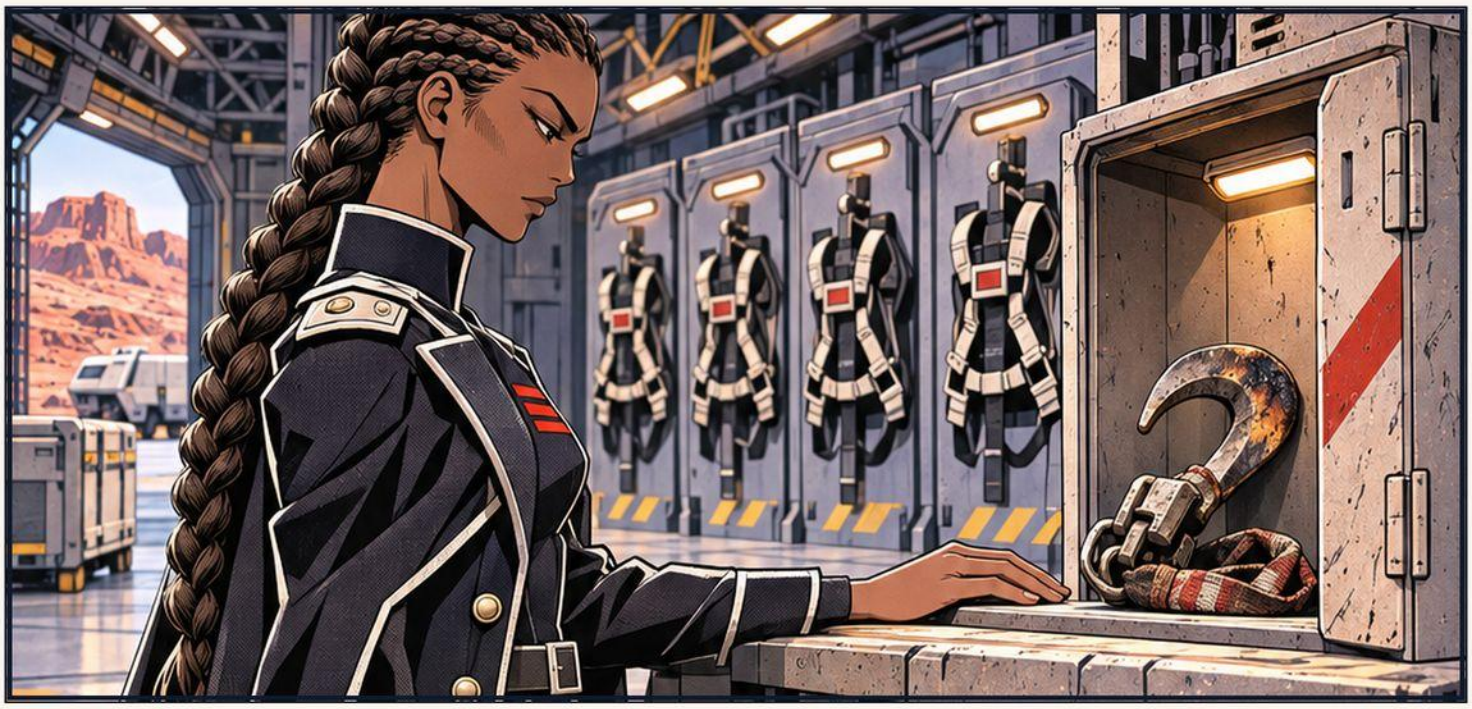
A seal washer is a little ring that stops a joint leaking. Rook had nearly eaten the plumbing.

TAVI

IONA

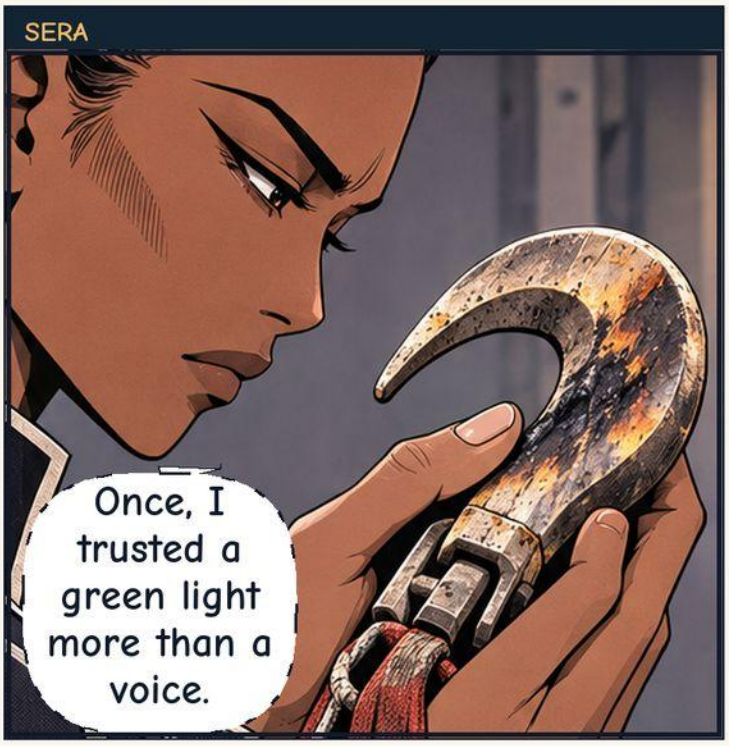
PIP / YEARS LATER

Tavi tapped the two lunch forks against a glass. Different notes. Acoustics: how sound behaves. His idea of dinner conversation.

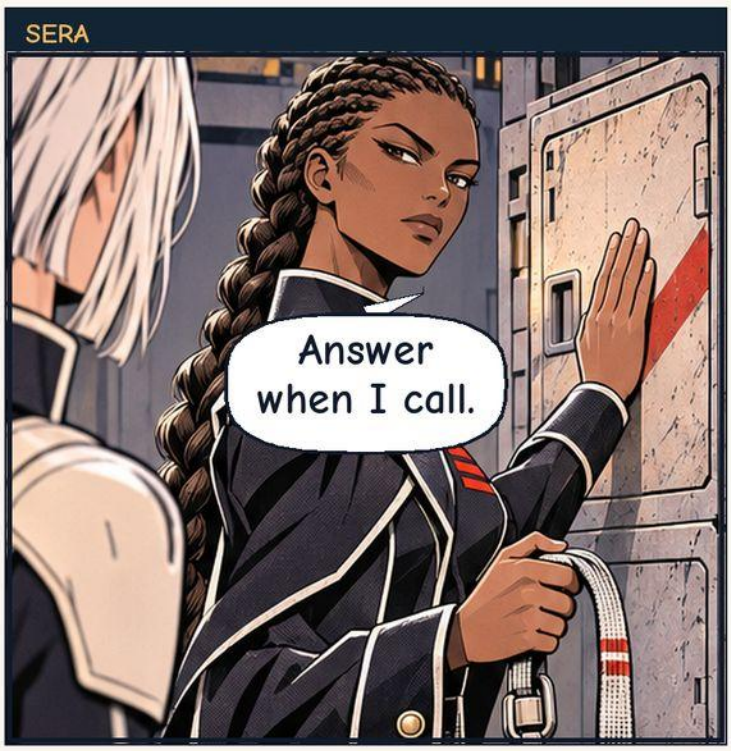


IONA

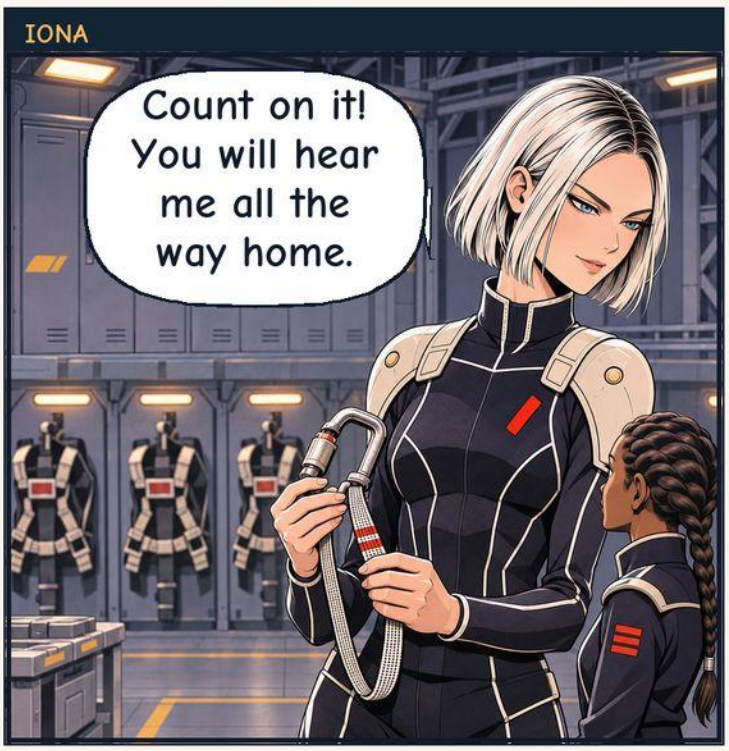
SERA



SERA



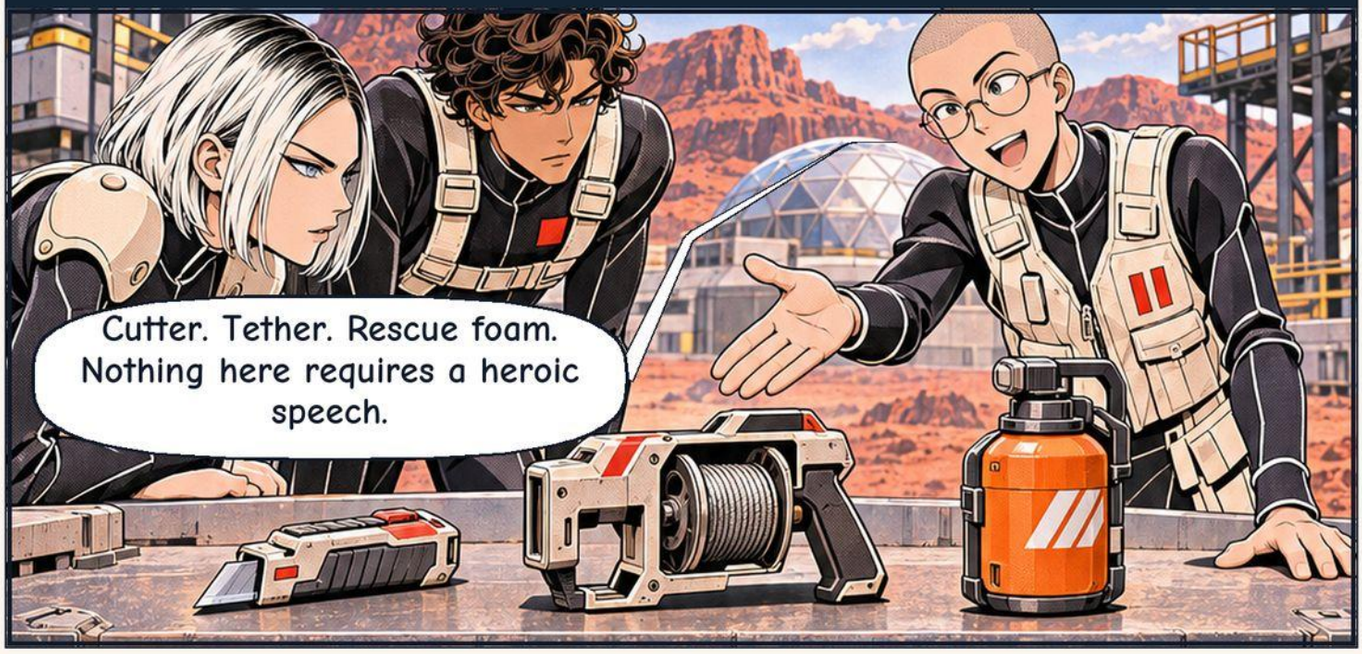
IONA



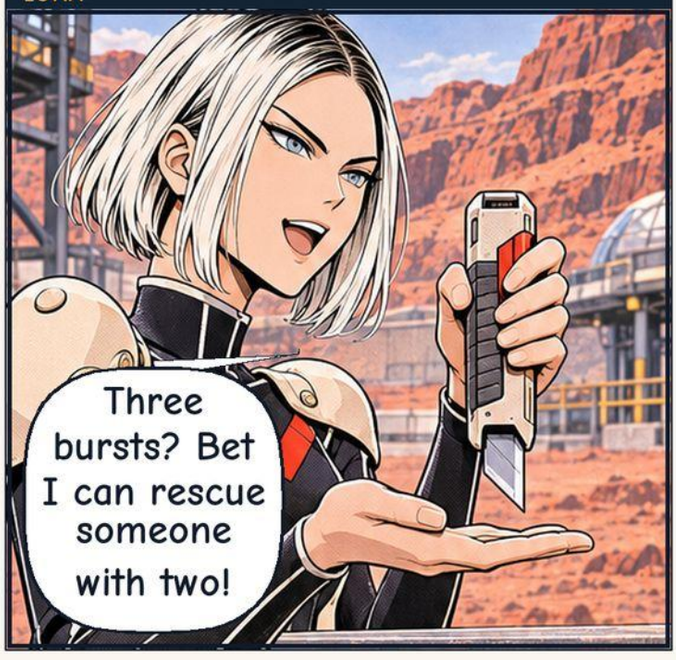
PIP / YEARS LATER

Tavi was our engineer. His cutter sliced metal; his tether was a safety line. The foam plugged leaks, not appetites.

TAVI



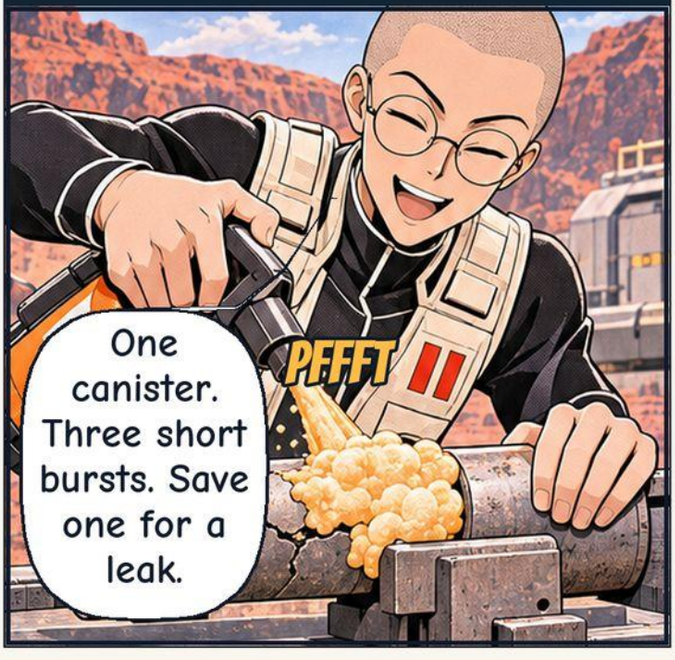
IONA



PIP / YEARS LATER

Tavi tested the first burst on a cracked pipe. The foam hardened over the leak. Two bursts left.

TAVI



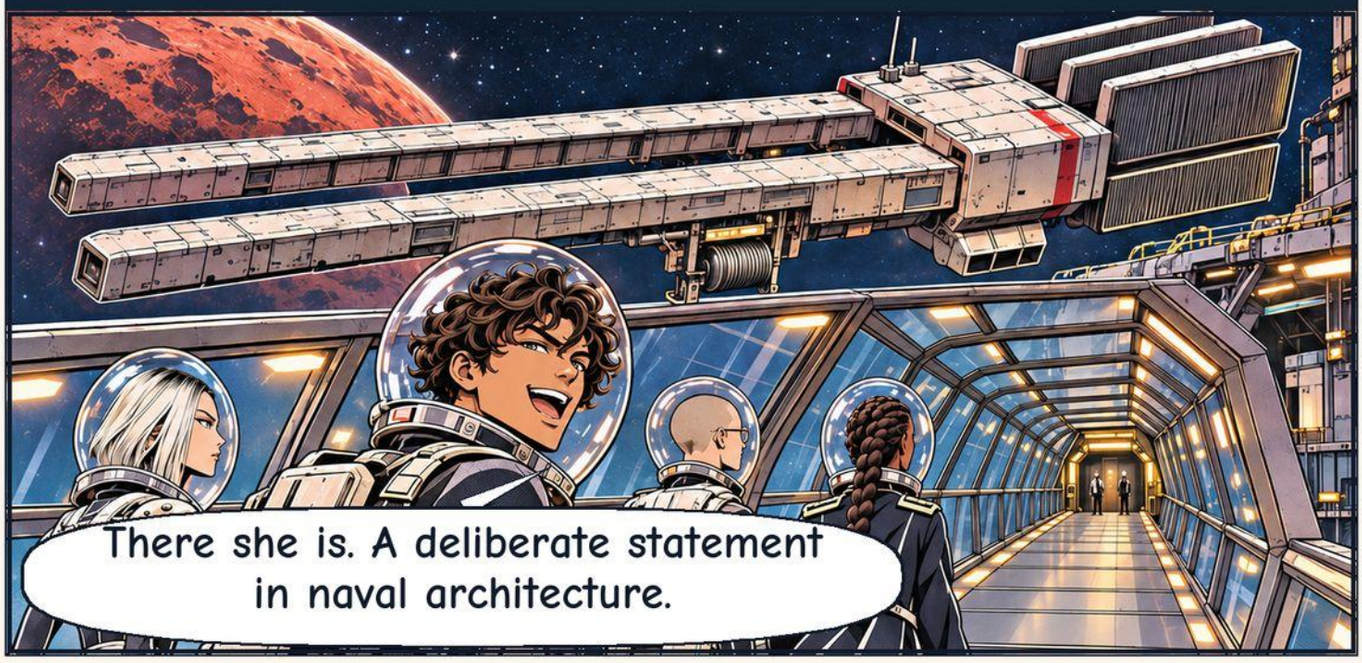
ROOK

SERA

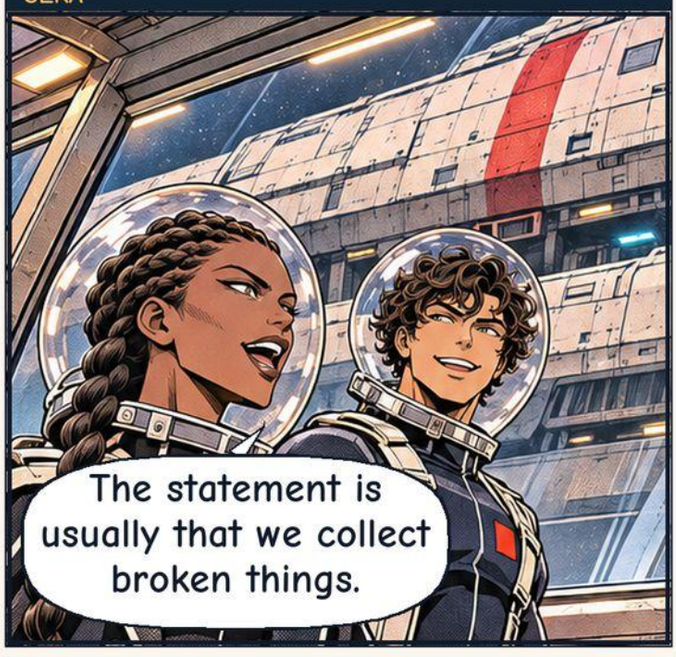
PIP / YEARS LATER

Needlewake was our rescue ship. Moth was the little launch she carried.

ROOK



SERA

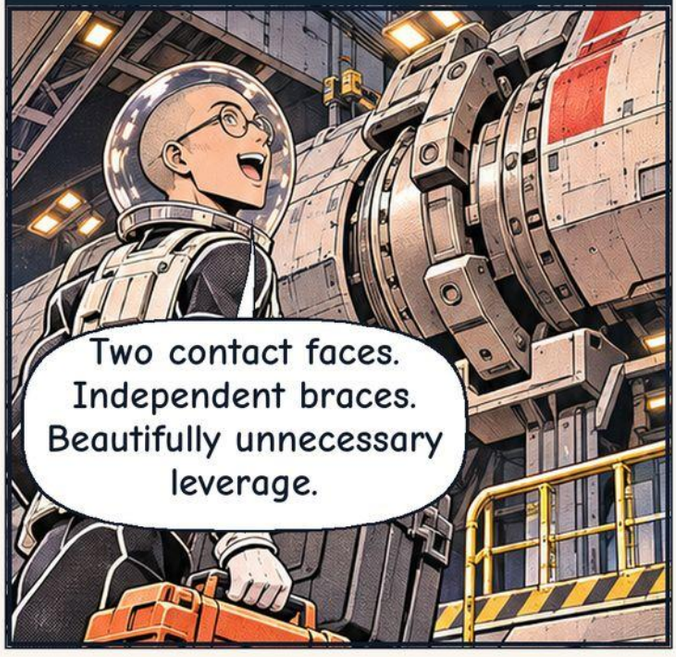


IONA

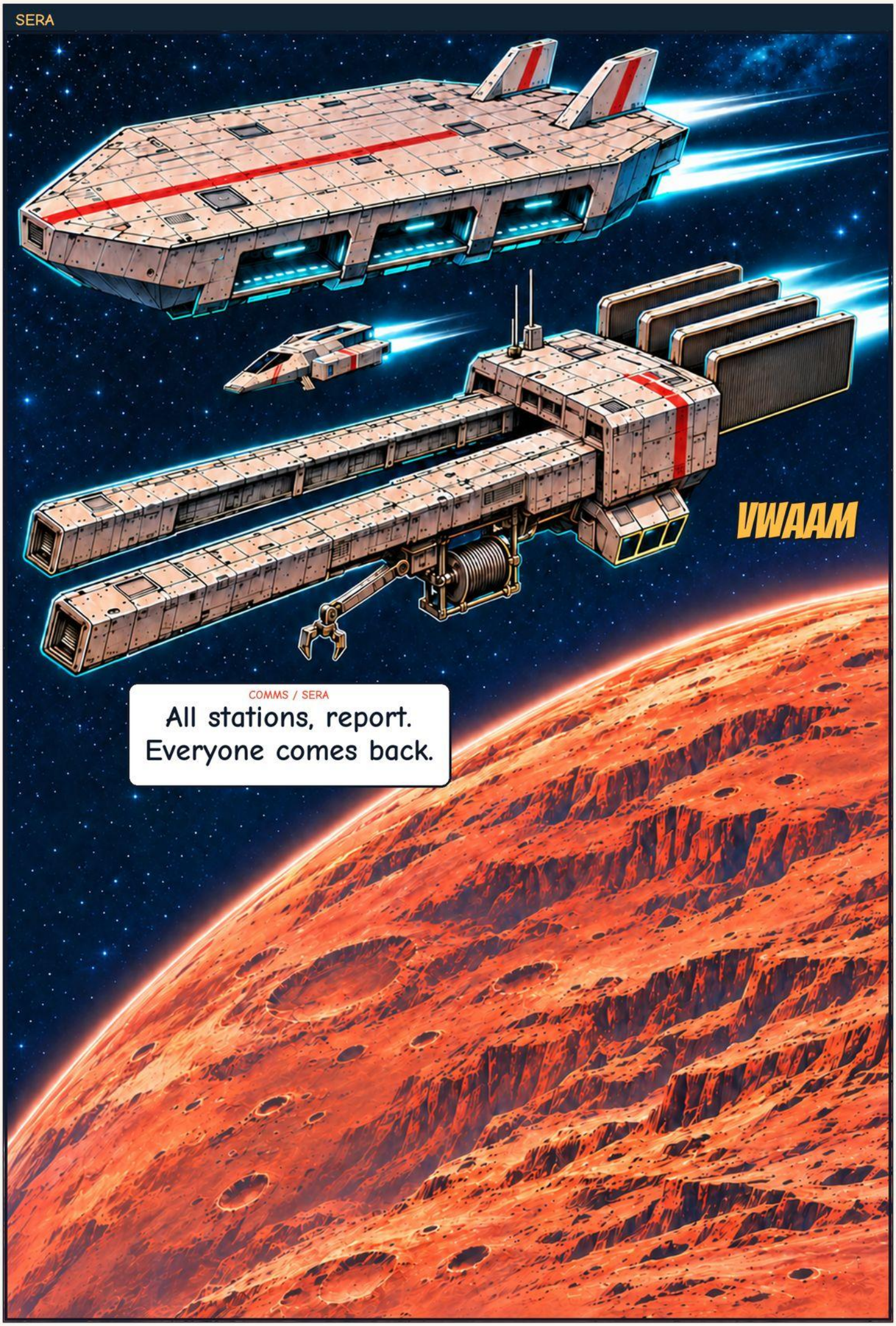
PIP / YEARS LATER

Contact faces pass vibrations; braces hold them steady. The broad ship beside us was the carrier Civic Mercy, under expedition command.

TAVI



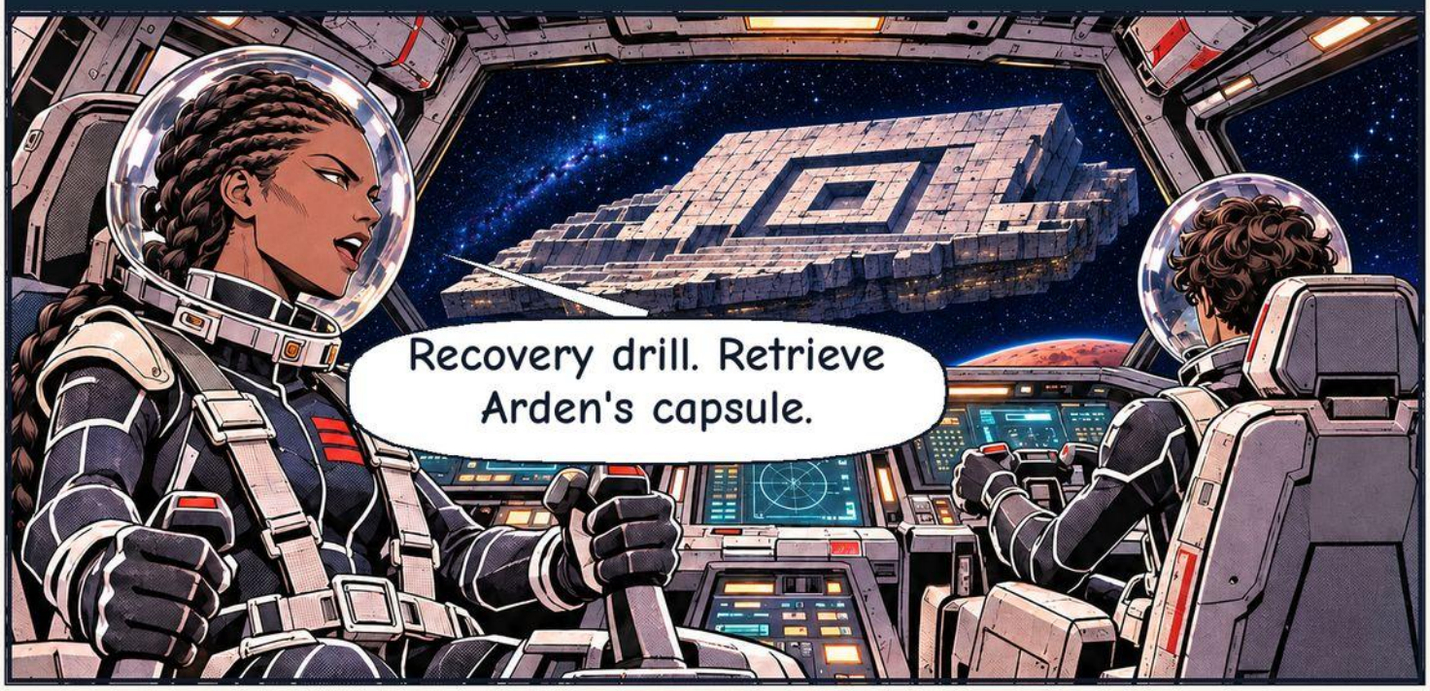
ROOK


SERA
VWAAM
COMMS / SERA
All stations, report.
Everyone comes back.

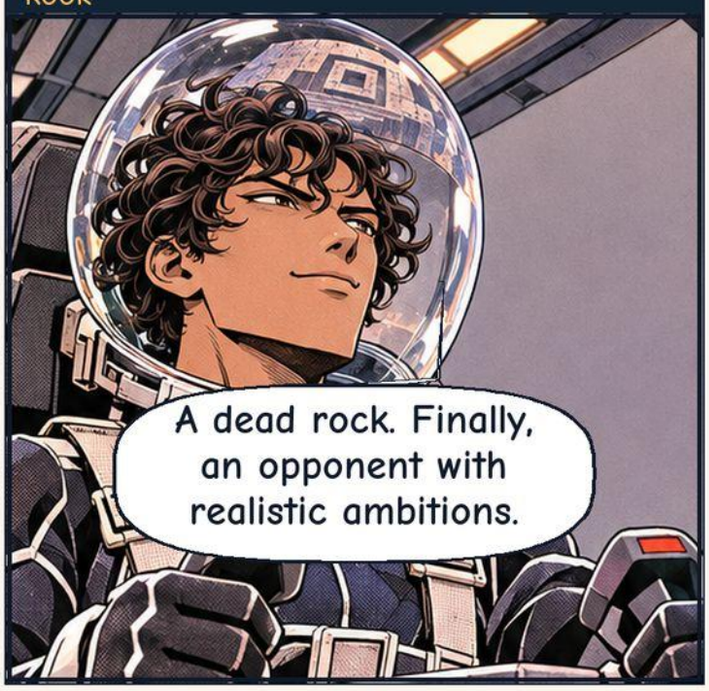
PIP / YEARS LATER

The capsule was for practice. My jammed seat restraint wasn't.

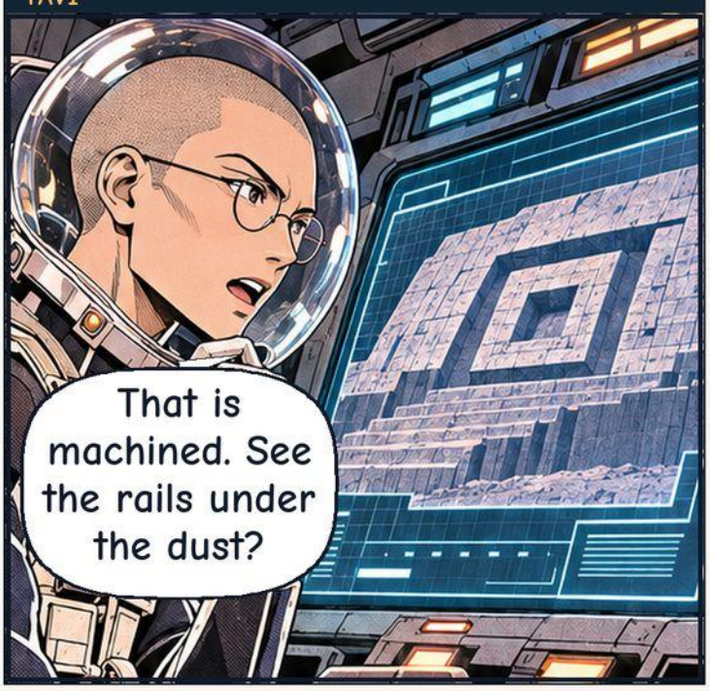
SERA



ROOK

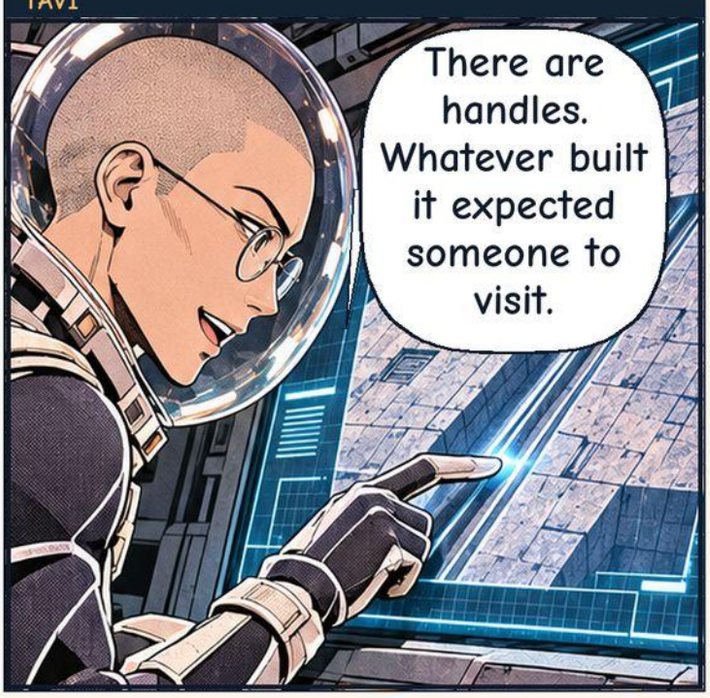


TAVI



IONA

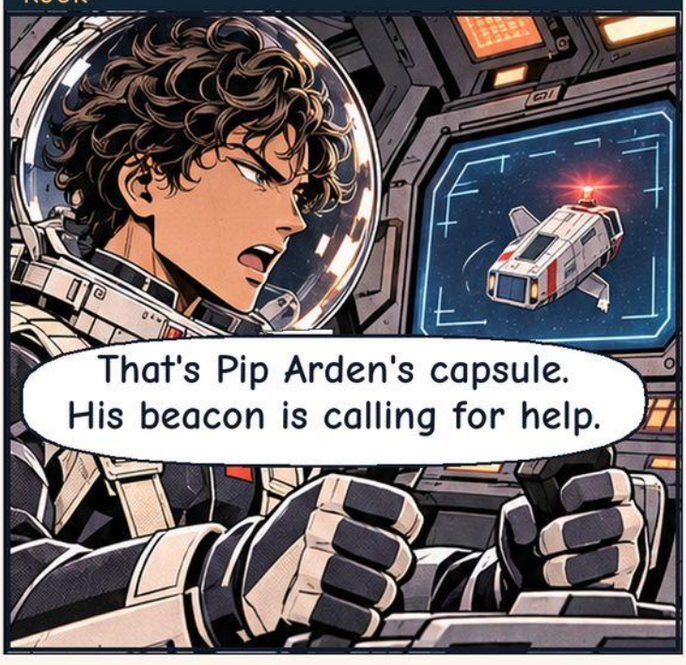
TAVI



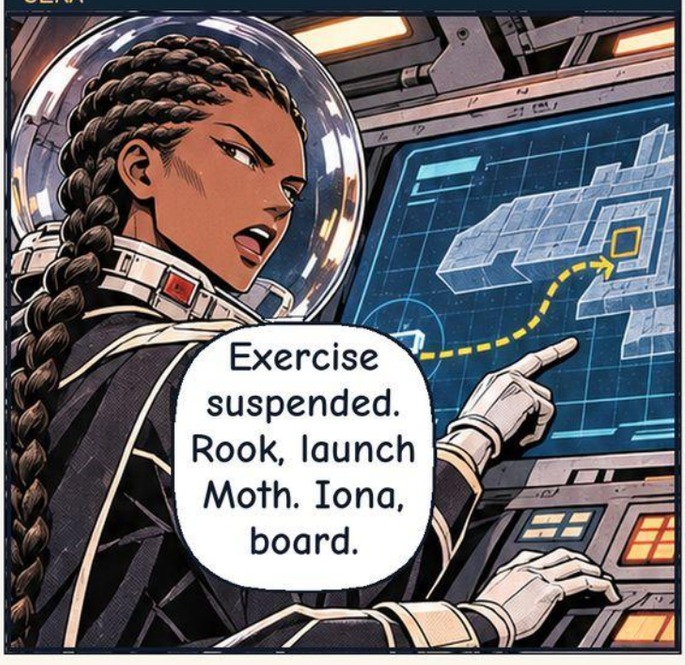
PIP / YEARS LATER

We'd been sent to practise beside what the academy called a dead rock. My capsule drifted against it; the bent restraint pinned my leg.

ROOK



SERA



IONA

PIP / YEARS LATER

The yellow one in my other seat was an inflatable training dummy. The shaking one was me.

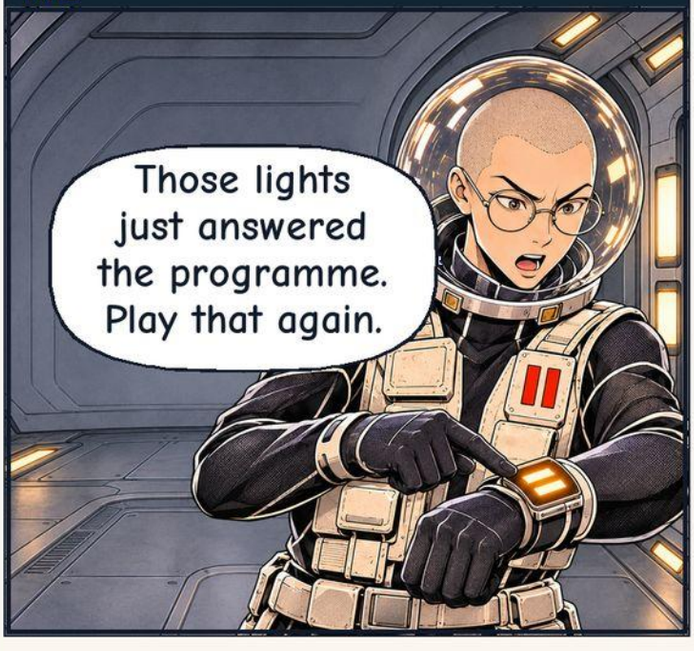
PIP ARDEN / CADET

BEAM

PIP / YEARS LATER

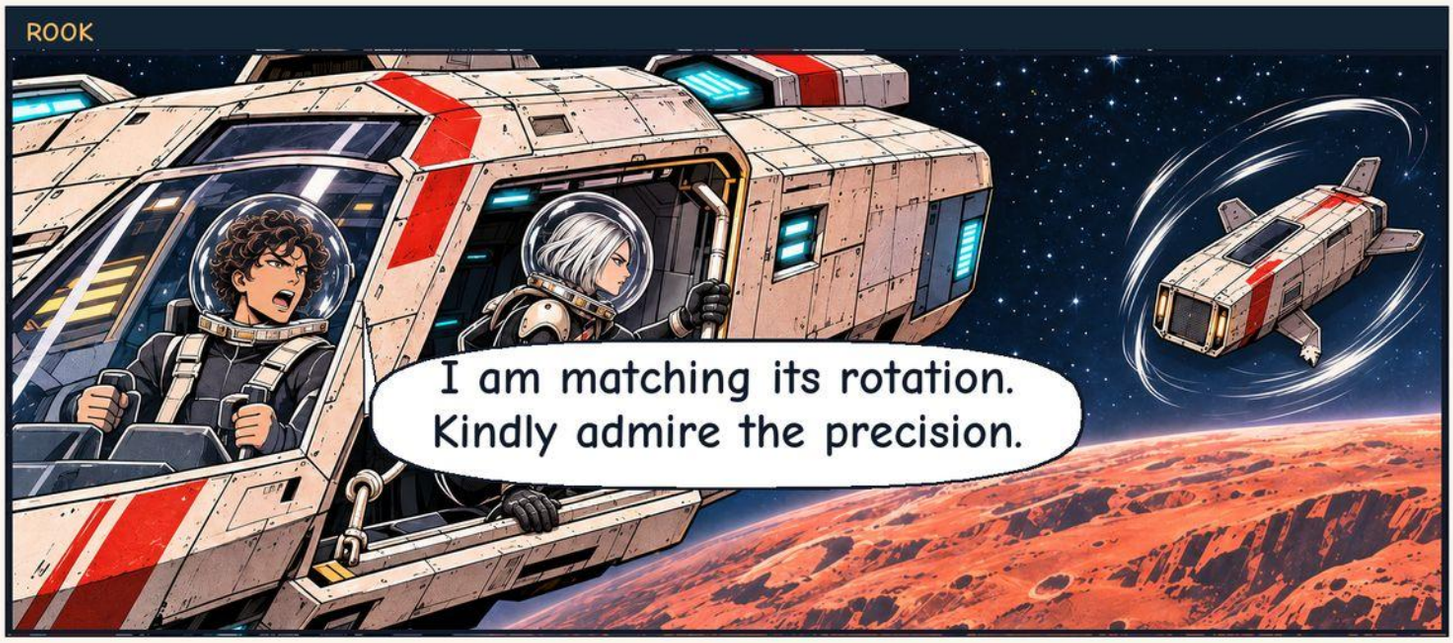
Its radio receiver picked up the jingle and turned the beat into movement commands. The metal contacts fed the same controls.

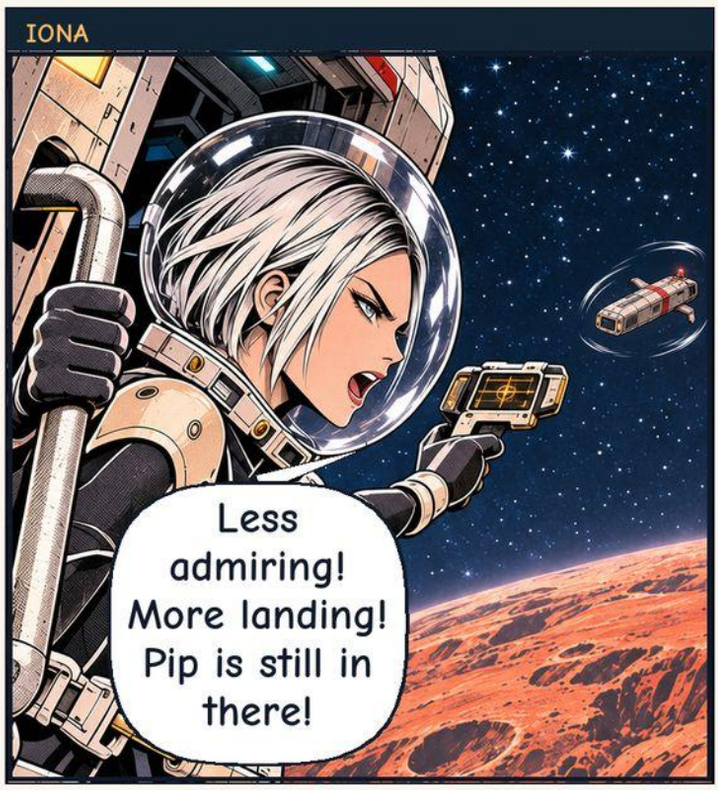
TAVI

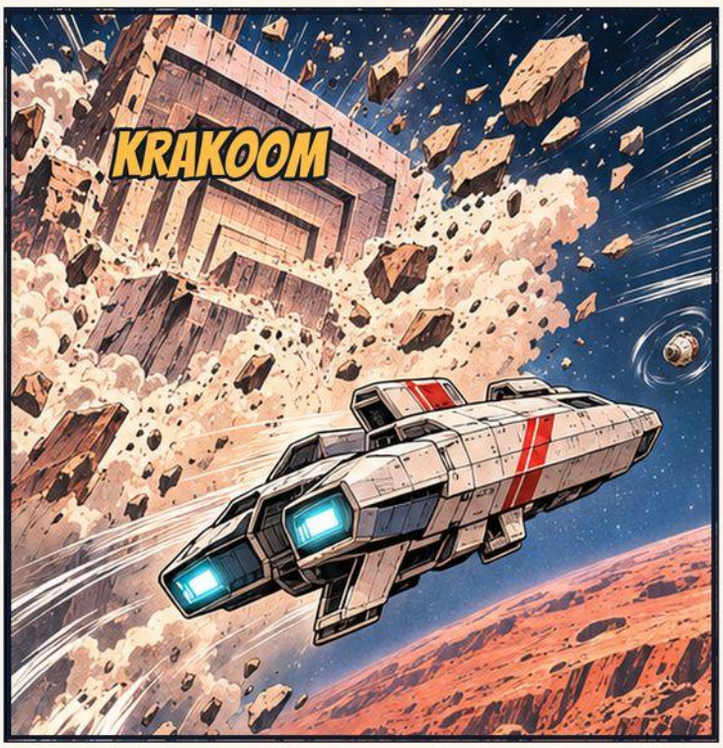


SERA

IONA

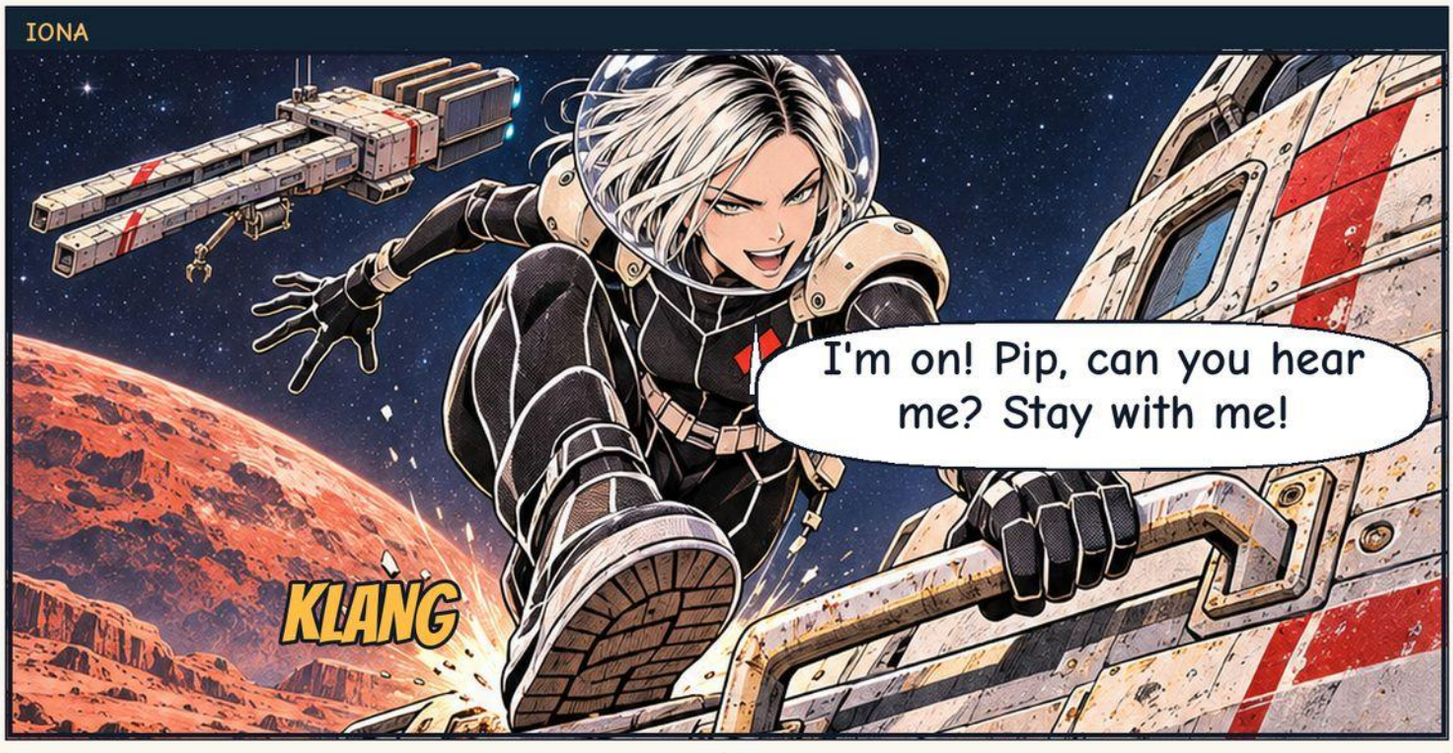

ROOK
I am matching its rotation. Kindly admire the precision.

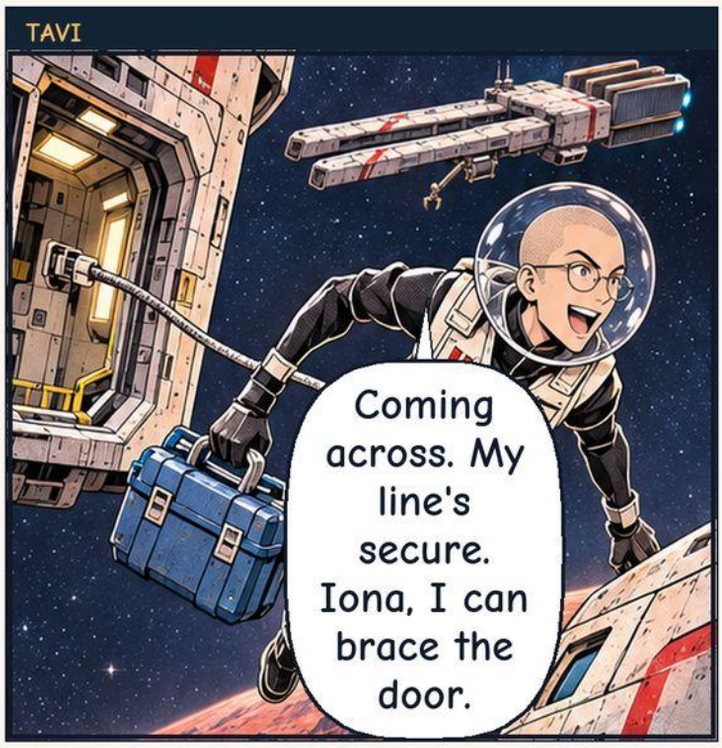

IONA
Less admiring! More landing! Pip is still in there!

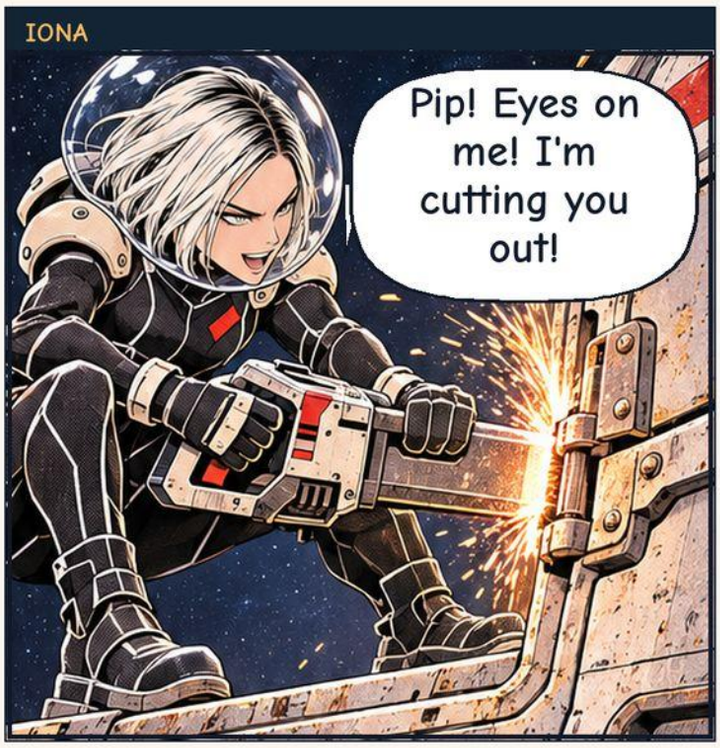

KRAKOOM

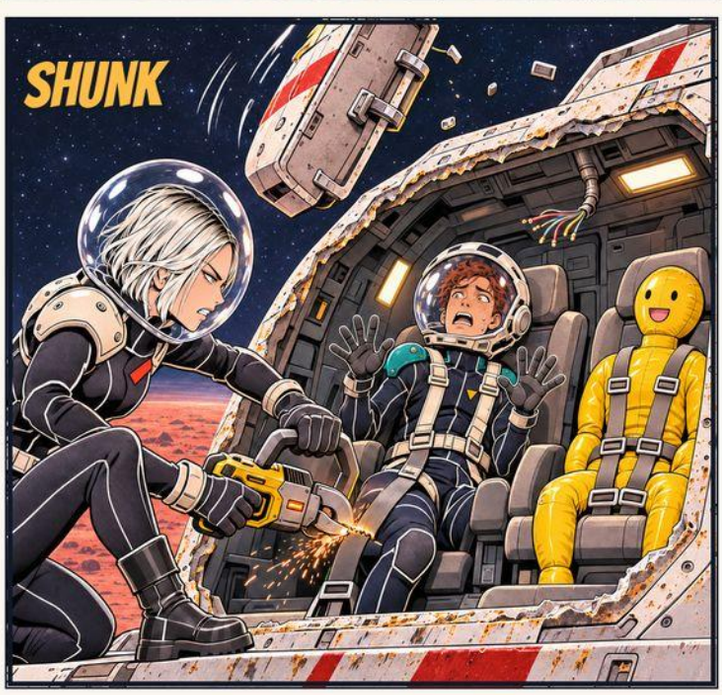
ROOK
I can't get closer. Iona, the hatch is clear. Stay clipped.

IONA
VWAAM
Keep it open, hotshot! I'm bringing someone back!


IONA
I'm on! Pip, can you hear me? Stay with me!
KLANG


TAVI
Coming across. My line's secure. Iona, I can brace the door.


IONA
Pip! Eyes on me! I'm cutting you out!


SHUNK

IONA
Got you, Pip! Rook, take him! The dummy stays with us!

PIP / YEARS LATER

Maintenance drones were clearing the path for moving plates. One blocked Moth's hatch. Iona and Tavi couldn't follow me in.

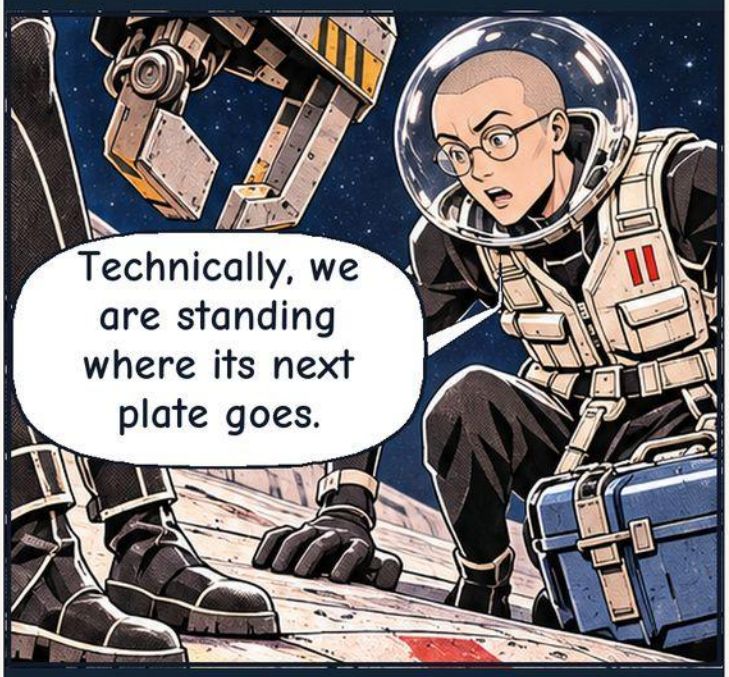
TAVI

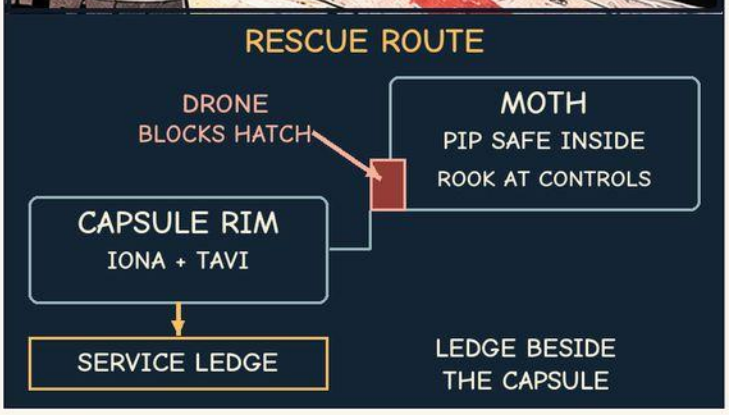
IONA

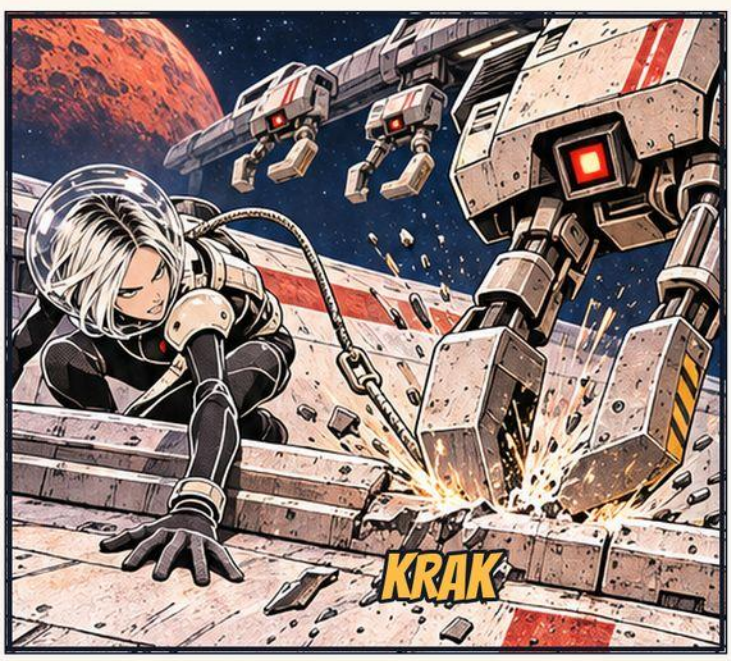
PIP / YEARS LATER

The exercise towline still joined Moth to the empty capsule. Beside it lay a service ledge, within Iona and Tavi's reach.

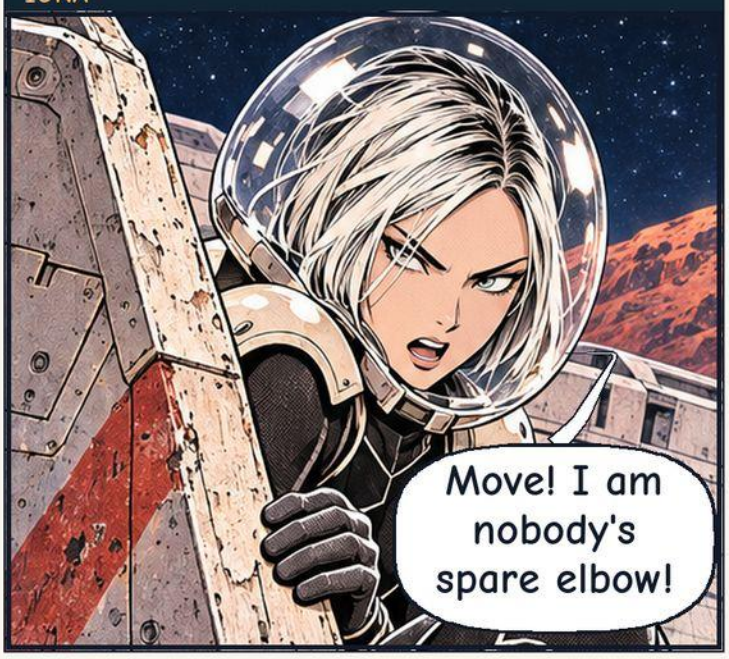
TAVI







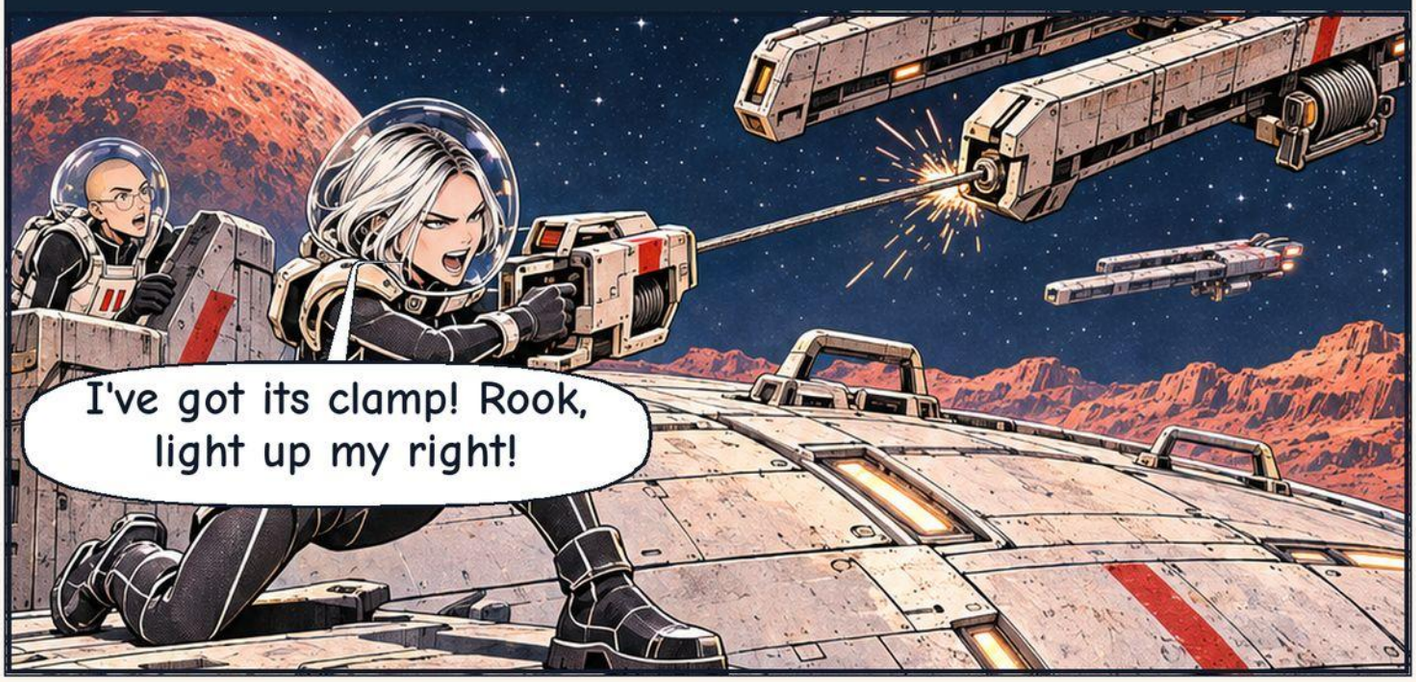
IONA



PIP / YEARS LATER

Iona's own safety line stayed clipped. The second line caught a drone's clamp; she braced it while Tavi reached the joint.

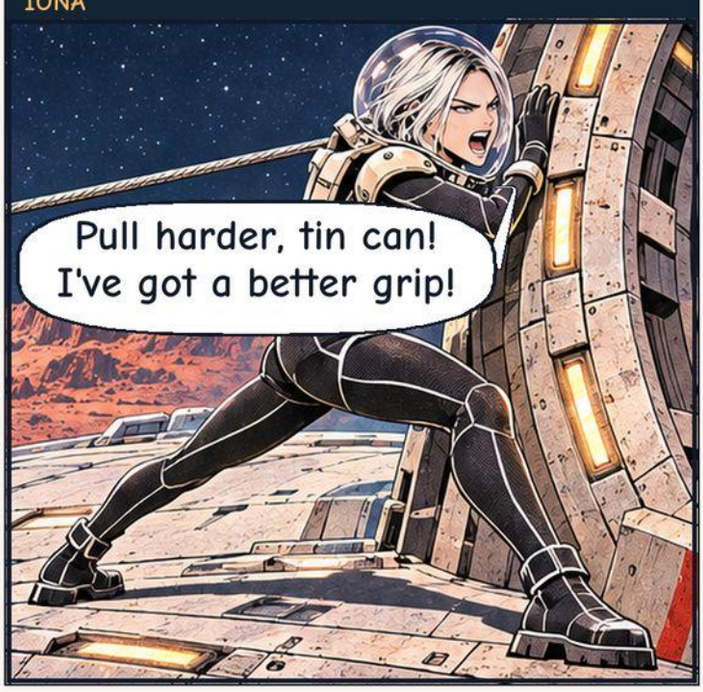
IONA



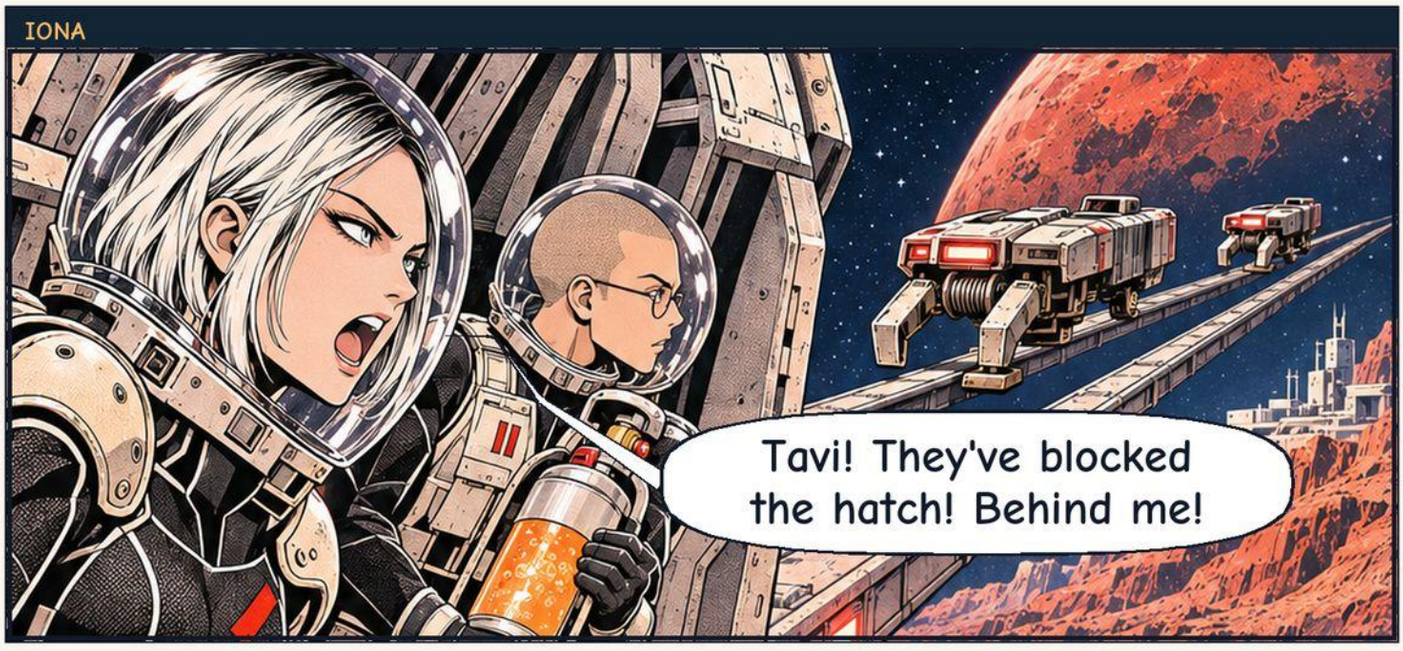
ROOK

TAVI

IONA



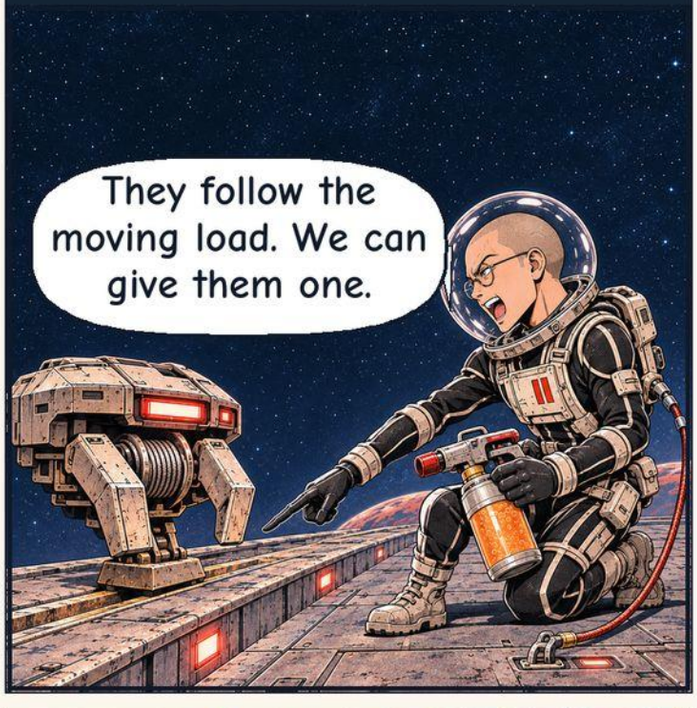
TAVI



PIP / YEARS LATER

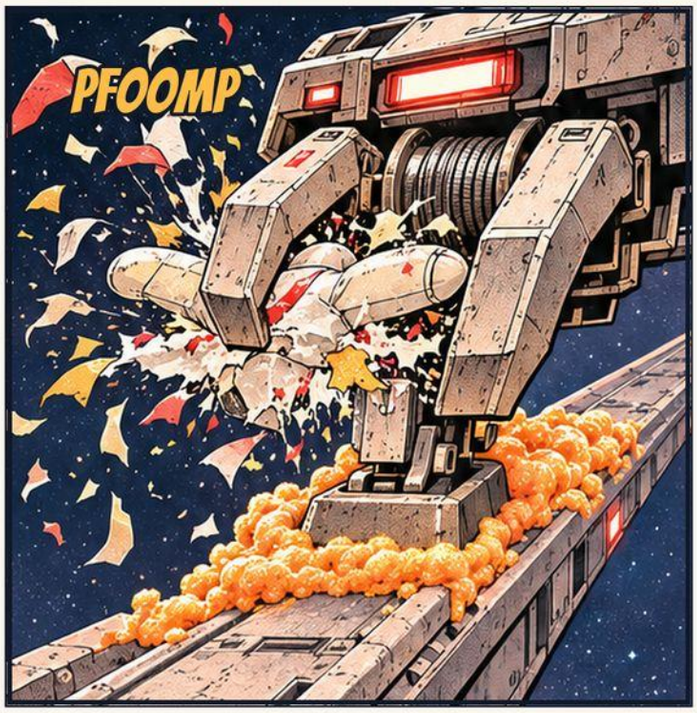
Tavi sprayed the rail. The dummy lured a drone onto the foam. One burst left.

TAVI



PIP / YEARS LATER

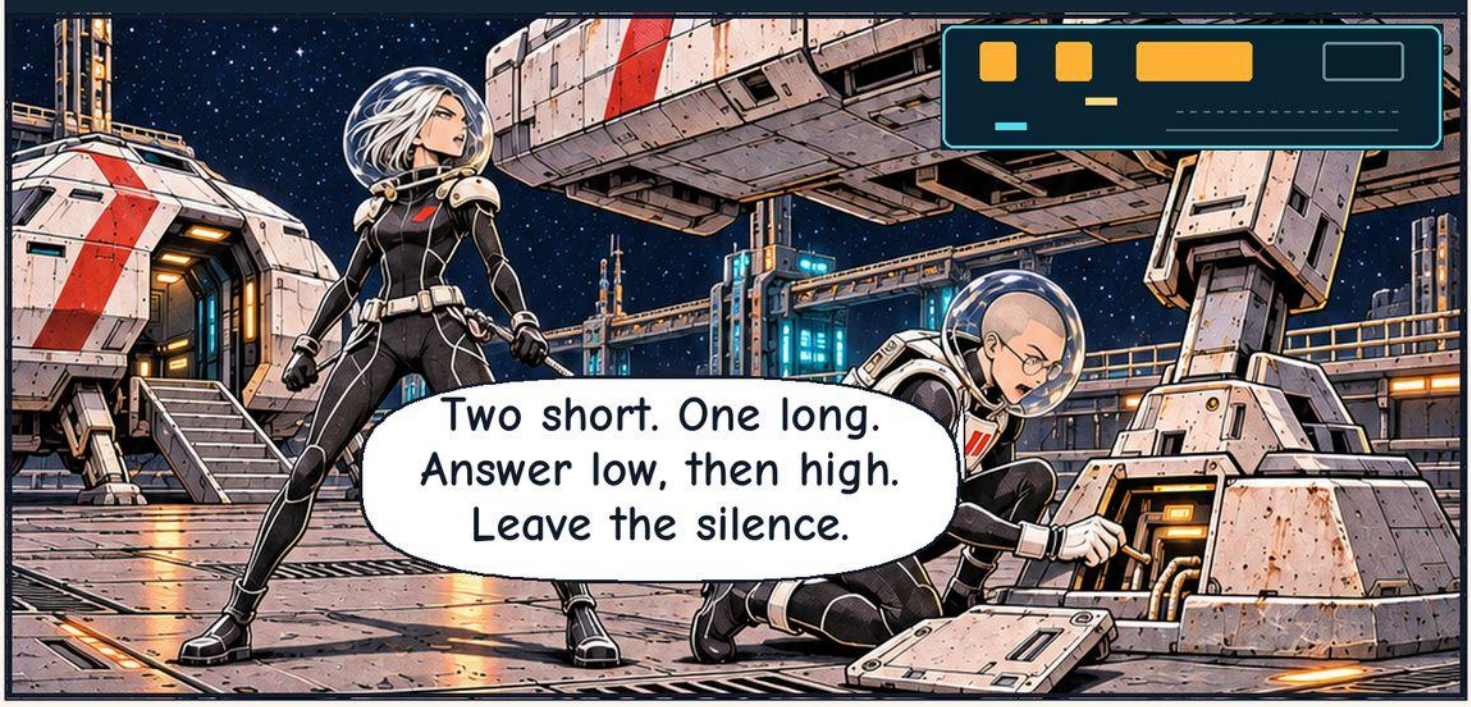
That was the inflatable cadet. I was belted inside Moth.



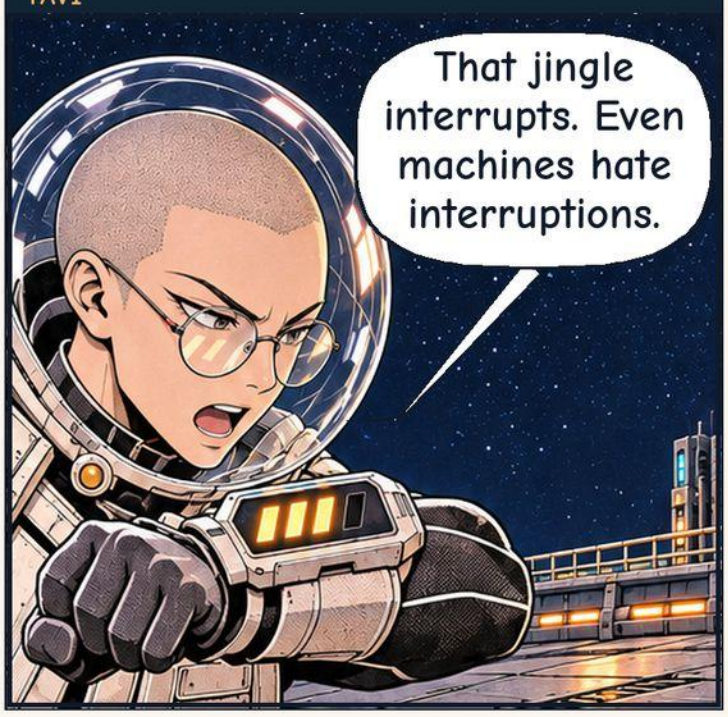
PIP / YEARS LATER

Two springy contacts rang low and high. Their marks lined up after the three lamp strokes. Tavi tried them in that order.

TAVI



TAVI



PIP / YEARS LATER

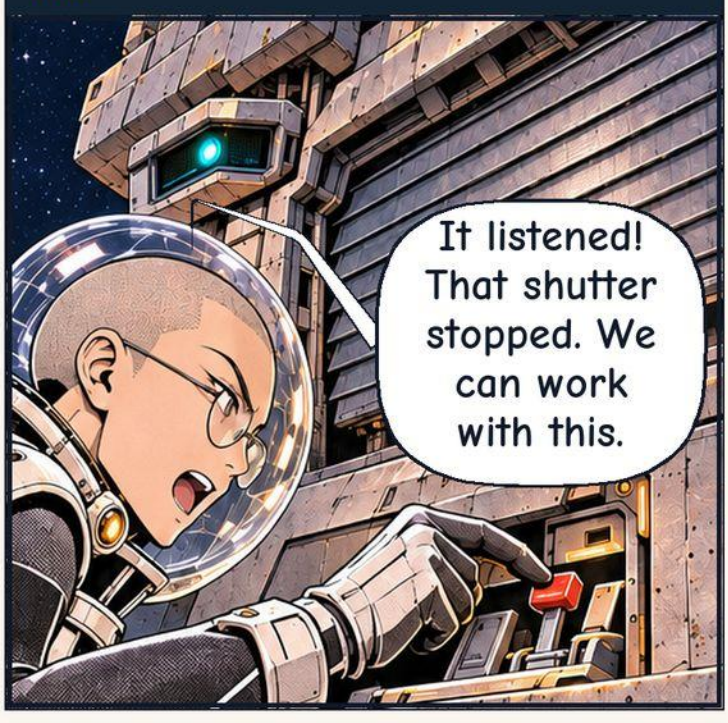
Iona had cut off the capsule door. Now she held it between Tavi and a drone's clamp.

IONA

PIP / YEARS LATER

He worked the lever: low, high, hands off. The shutter stopped. We called the bigger machine the World Clock.

TAVI



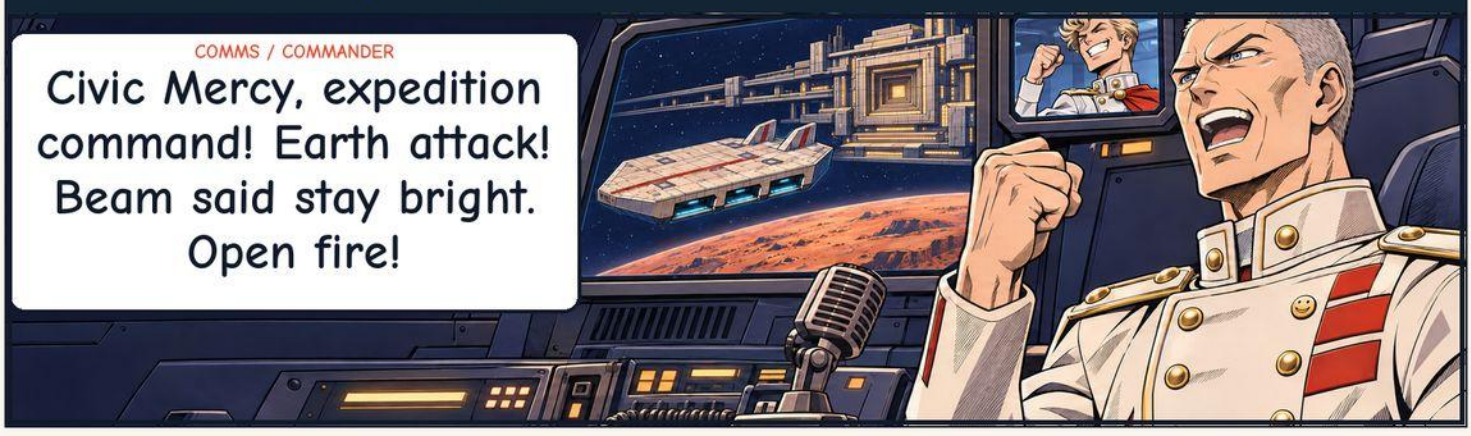
IONA

GROOON
COMMS / TAVI
We have been fighting a doorbell. That is the house.

PIP / YEARS LATER

The Fleet called Earth the enemy. Civic Mercy's commander saw moving machinery and decided it was an Earth attack. He fired while we were still there.

EXPEDITION COMMANDER / CIVIC MERCY

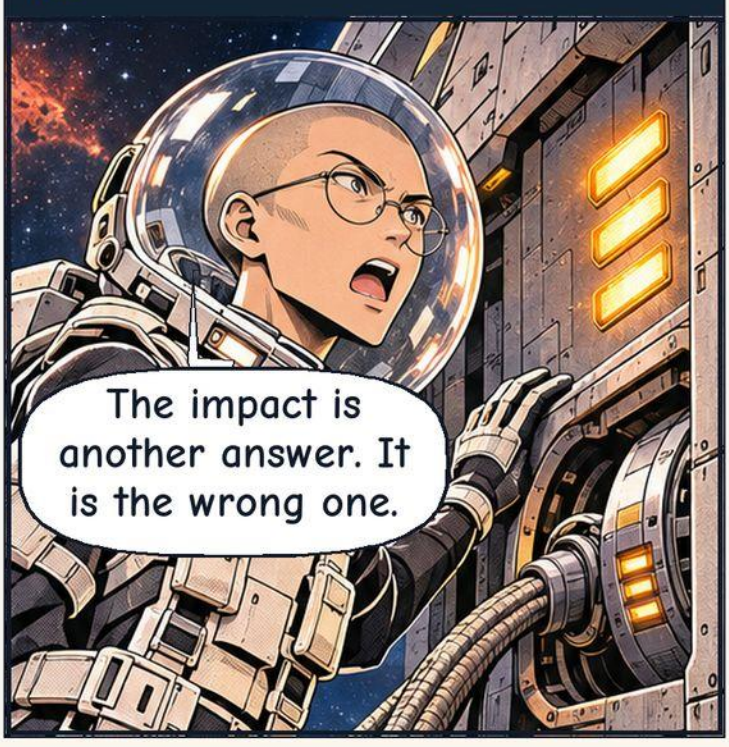


SERA

PIP / YEARS LATER

Tavi tried the radio again after the blast. No response. The two metal contacts still worked.

TAVI

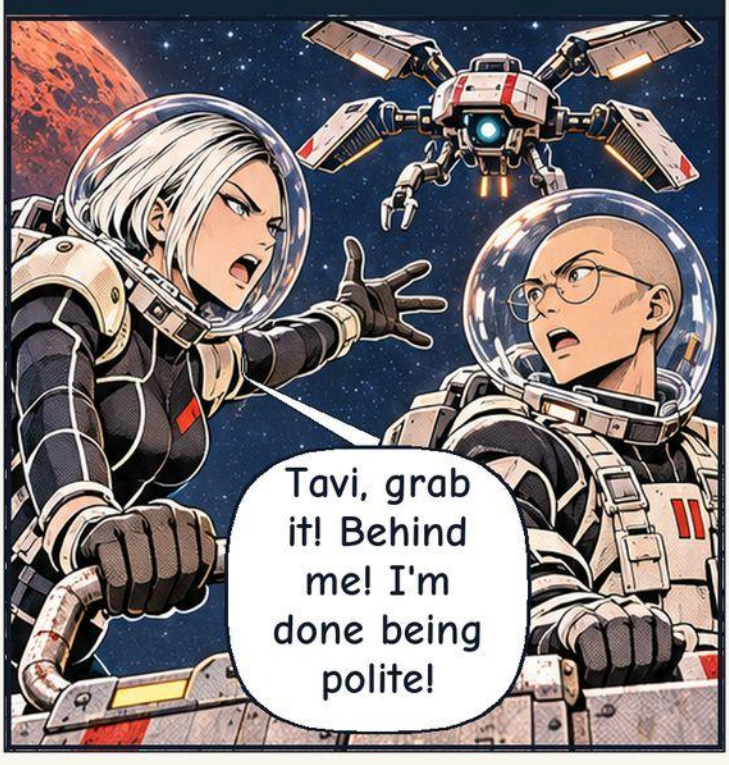


ROOK

PIP / YEARS LATER

The shutter was closing across Moth's way out. Tavi reached for the core to delay it; Iona covered him.

IONA



PIP / YEARS LATER

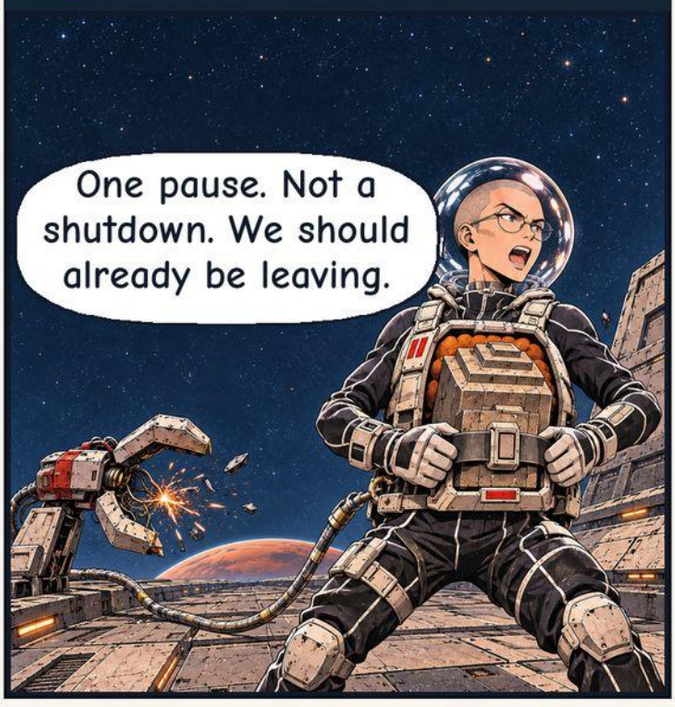
A governor controls movement. This core also sent signals. Unplugging it delayed one section, but the block itself kept working.

TAVI

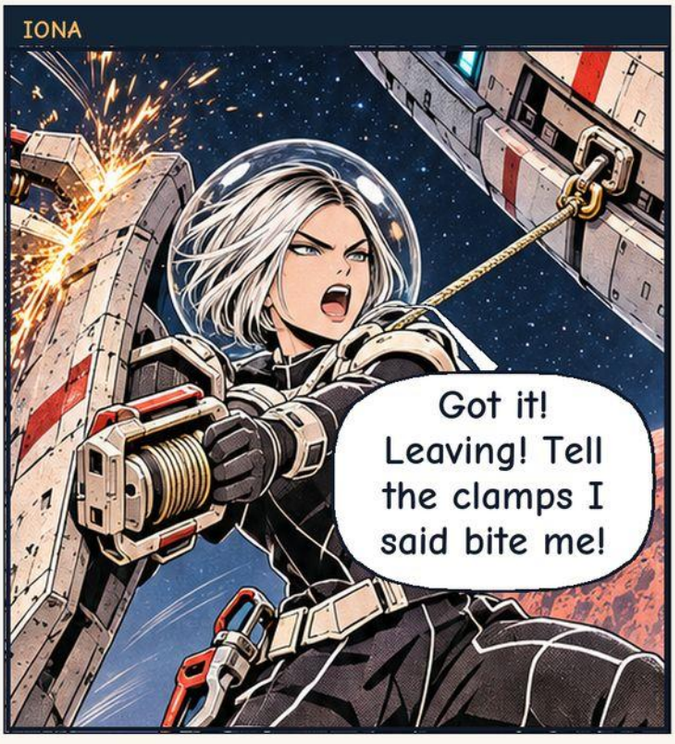
PIP / YEARS LATER

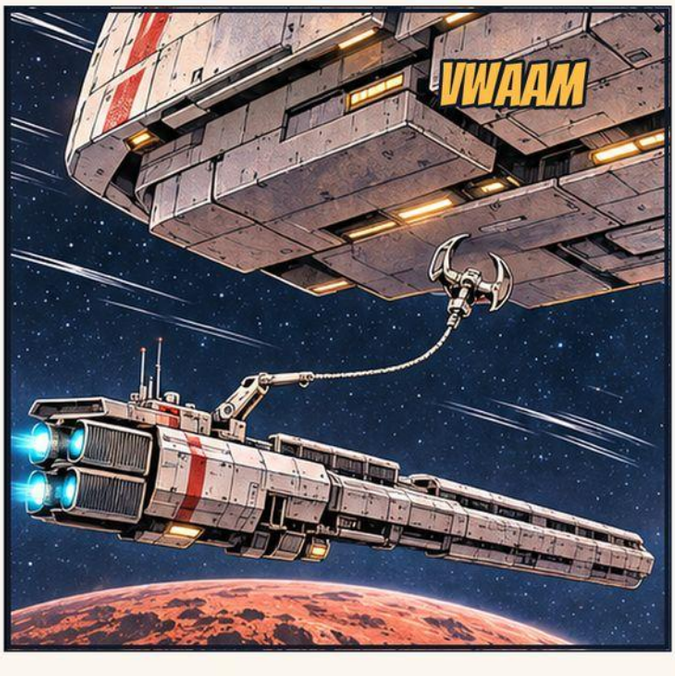
Only that section paused. The rest kept moving. Iona and Tavi still needed a route back to Moth.

TAVI



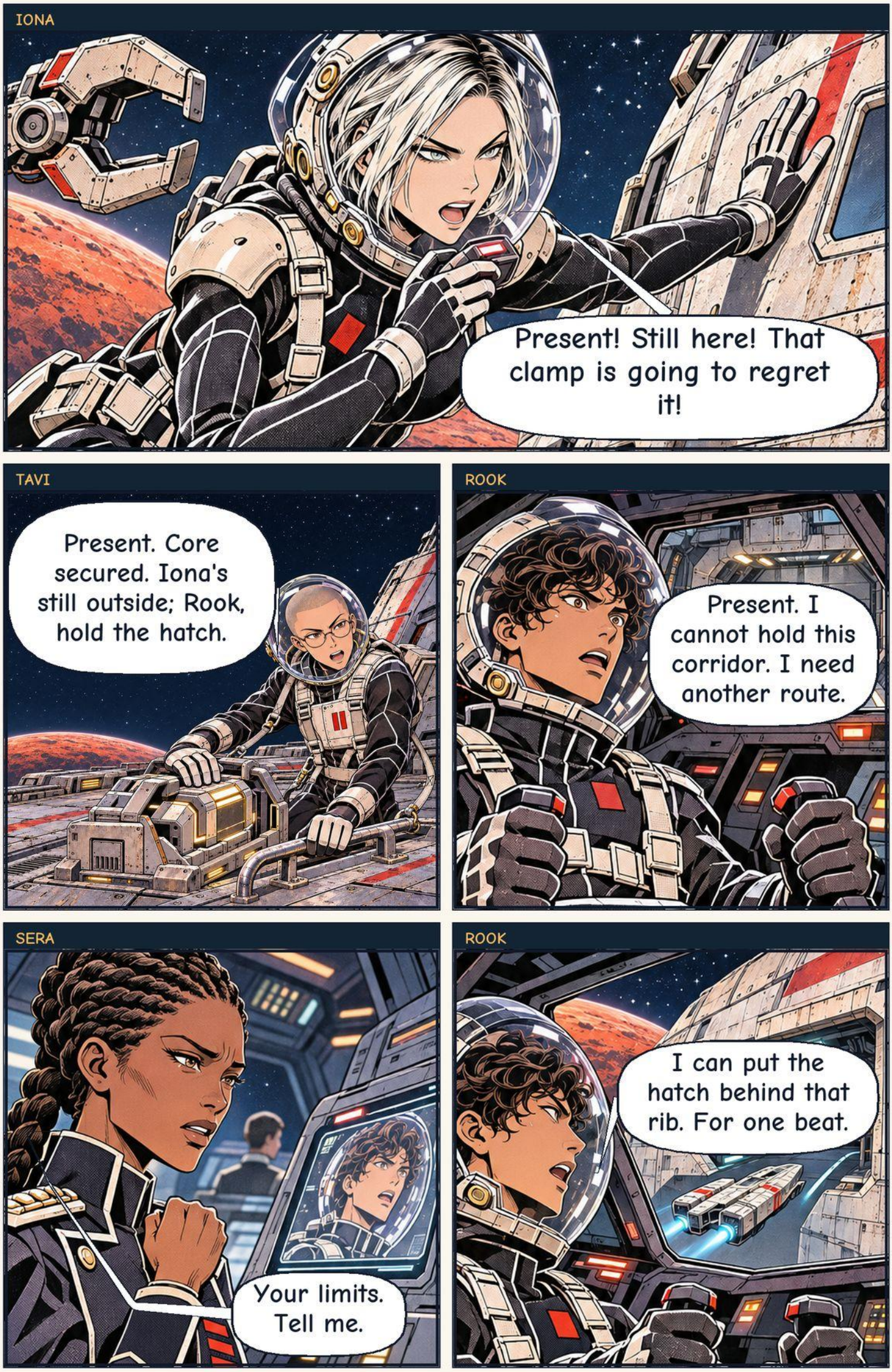
IONA



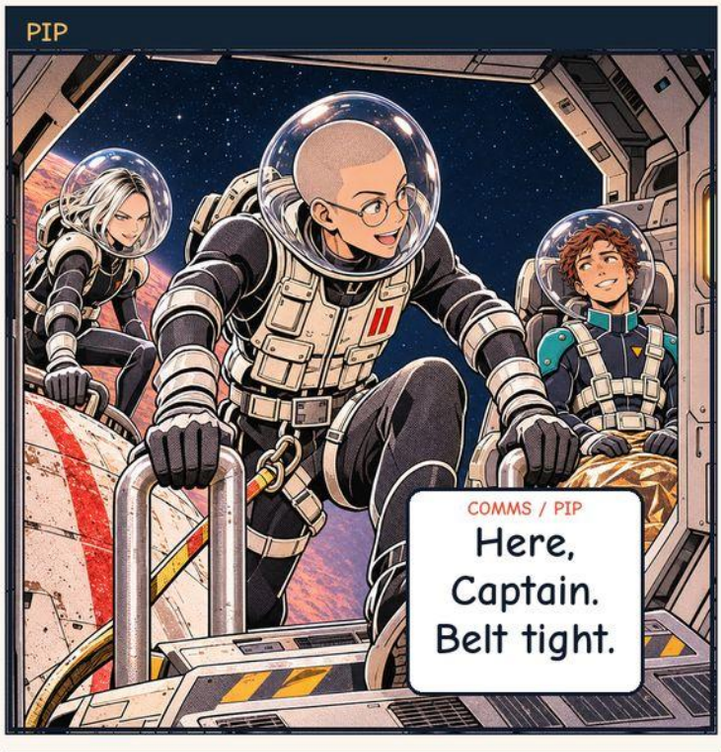


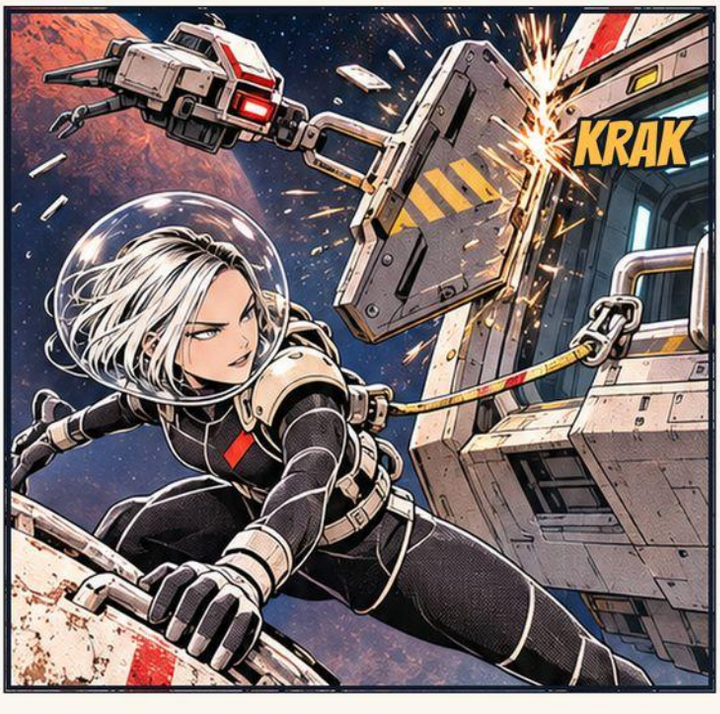
SERA

BEAM
FV
Excellent news! Our training exercise has acquired unprecedented educational value!
BEAM
FV
Those are not explosions. Those are opportunities becoming extremely visible.
BEAM
FV
Every survivor qualifies for our new Medal of Upright Excellence.
BEAM
FV
Remember, citizens: panic is merely enthusiasm facing the wrong direction.
BEAM
FV
Stay bright. Stay Martian. Please remain alive for the ceremony.


IONA
Present! Still here! That clamp is going to regret it!
TAVI
Present. Core secured. Iona's still outside; Rook, hold the hatch.
ROOK
Present. I cannot hold this corridor. I need another route.
SERA
Your limits. Tell me.
ROOK
I can put the hatch behind that rib. For one beat.

IONA
Your turn, Tavi! Move! I've got these scrap heaps!


PIP
COMMS / PIP
Here, Captain. Belt tight.

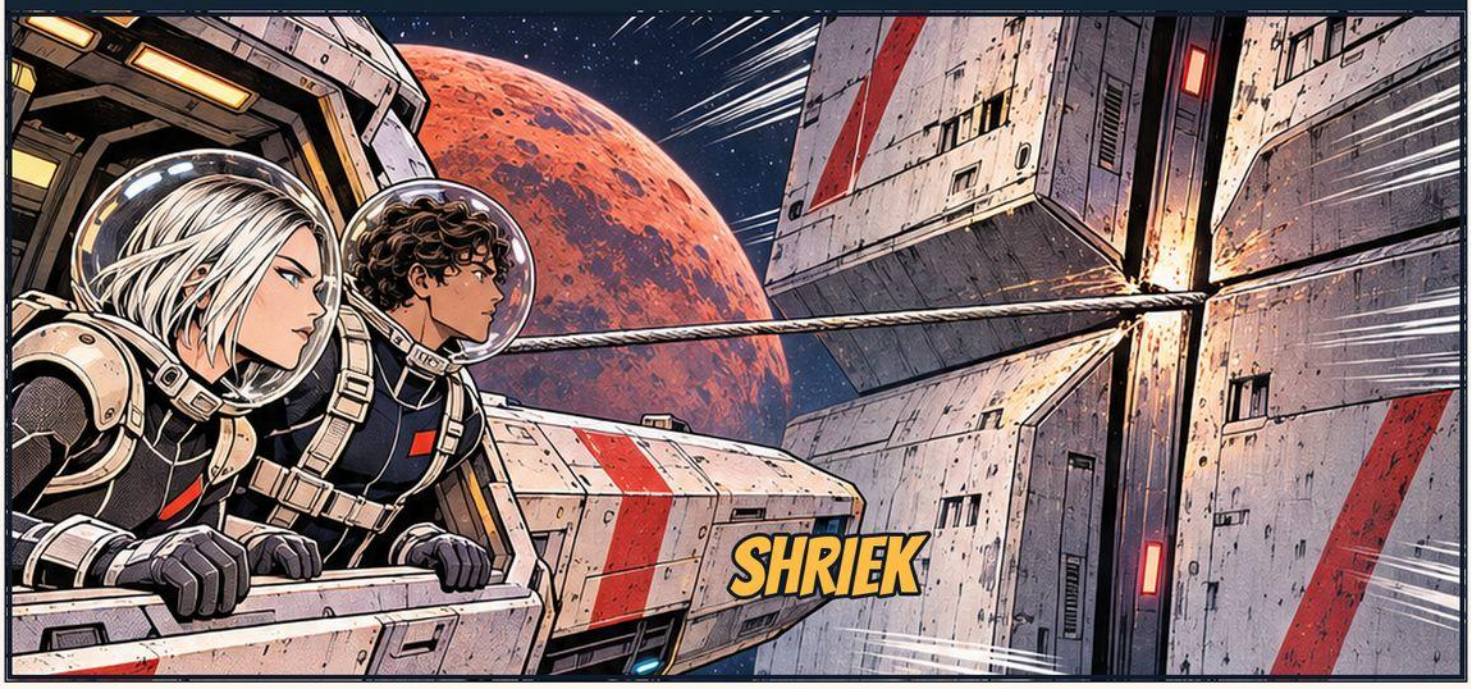

KRAK

ROOK
Your route back. Delivered exactly where you requested it.

IONA
Yes! That's my pilot! Tell anyone and we're racing again!

PIP / YEARS LATER

The towline hauled the empty capsule. It caught in a shutter and began dragging Moth in after it.

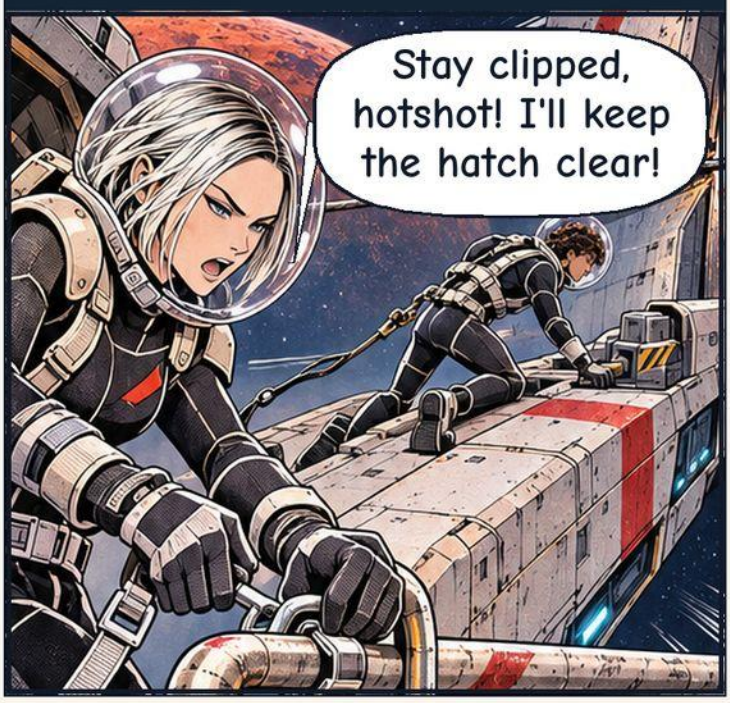


ROOK

PIP / YEARS LATER

Iona held the hatch while Tavi secured the core. Rook clipped his safety line and climbed out to the cutter beside the snagged towline.

IONA



PIP / YEARS LATER

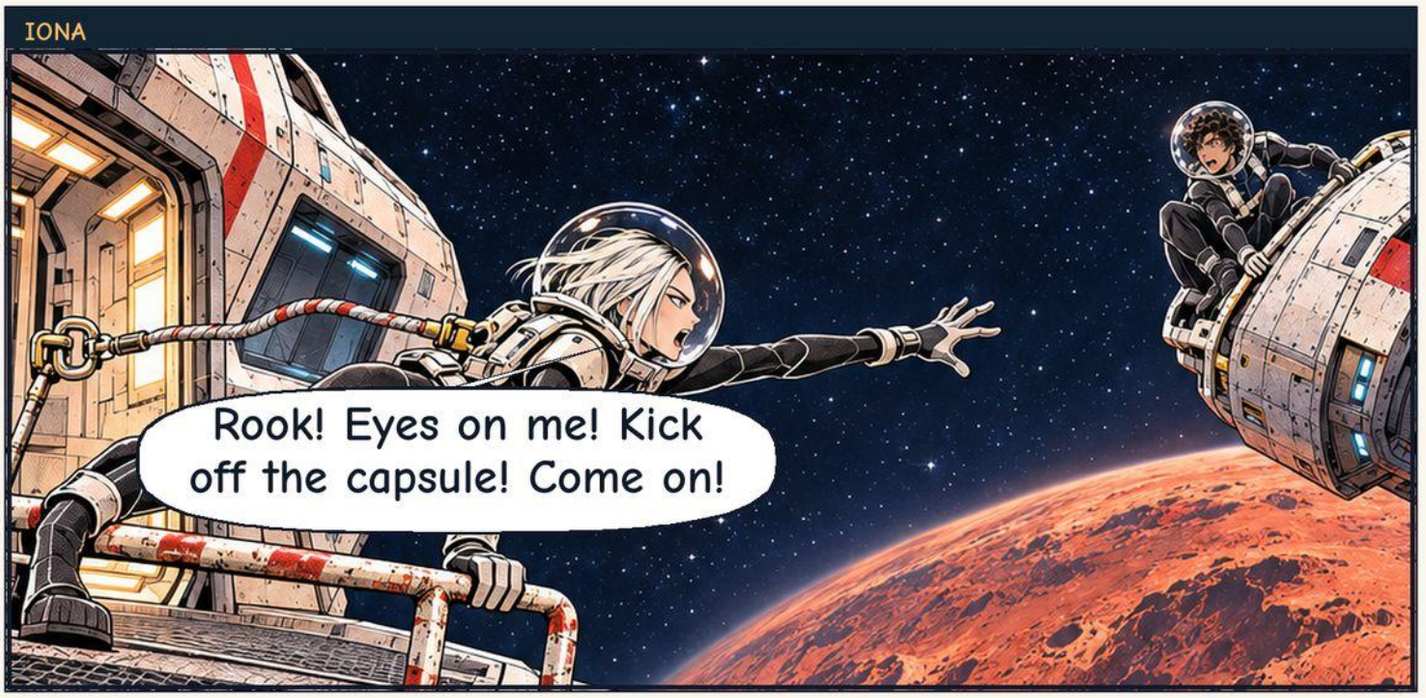
He cut the towline. Its loose end whipped back and sliced his separate safety tether. Now Rook was drifting too.

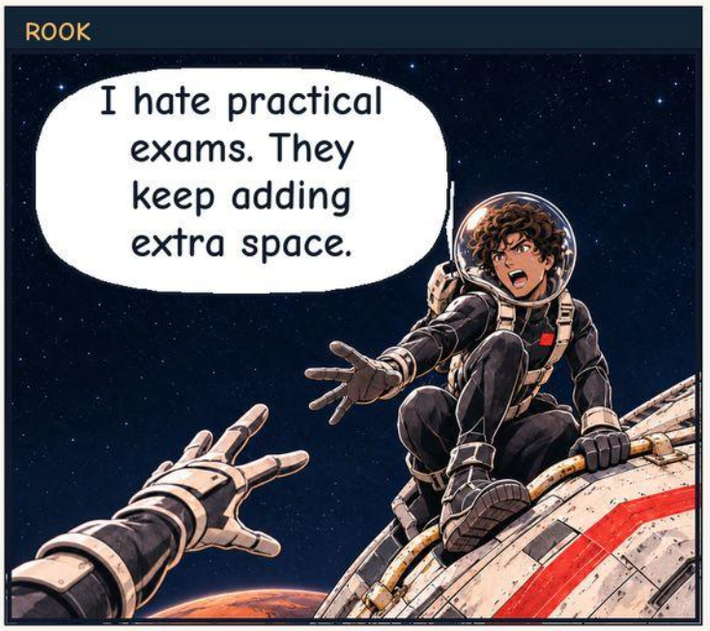
ROOK

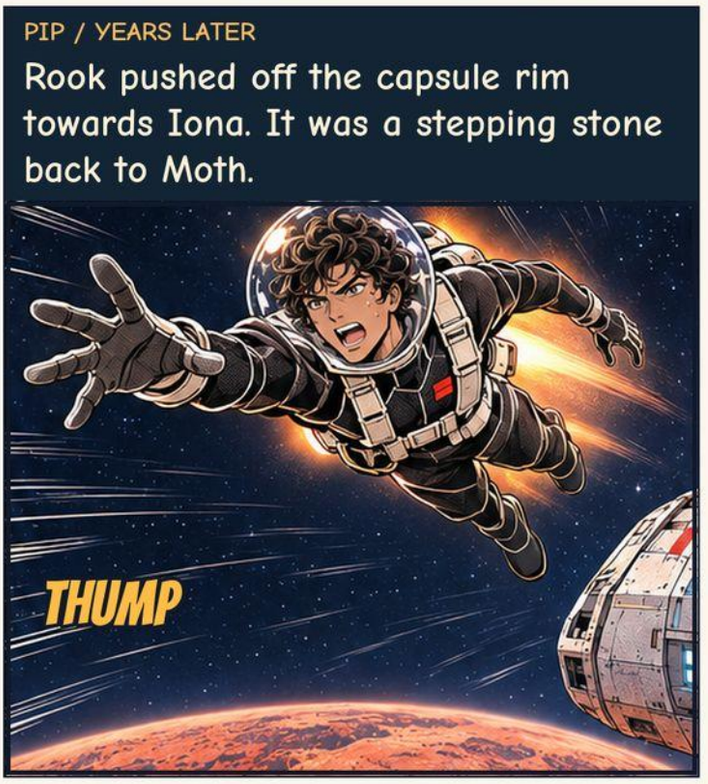
PIP / YEARS LATER

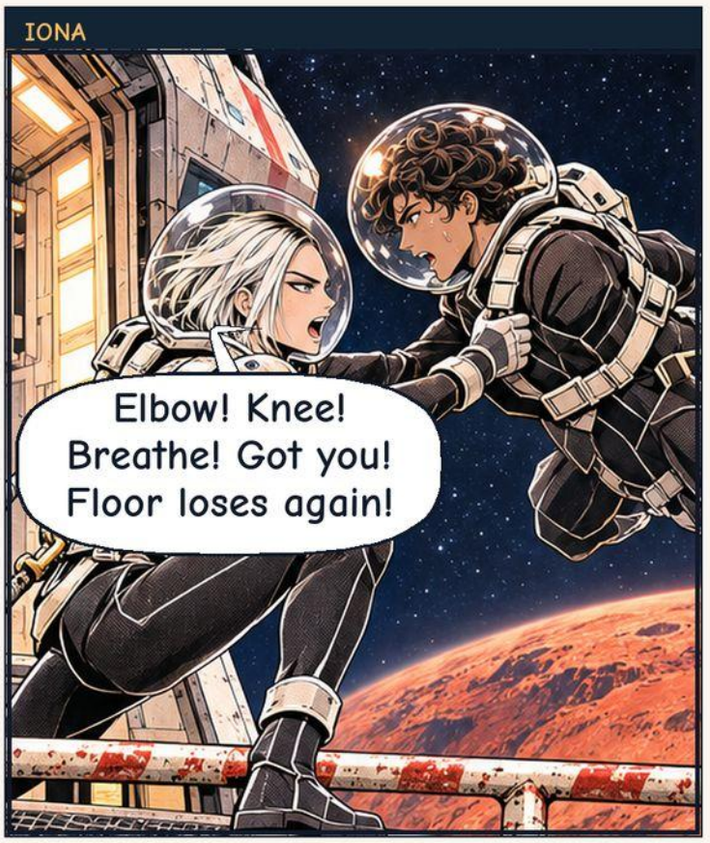
Rook drifted past the capsule. His boots could still reach its rim. Iona braced herself at Moth's hatch and reached out.

ROOK


IONA
Rook! Eyes on me! Kick off the capsule! Come on!


ROOK
I hate practical exams. They keep adding extra space.


PIP / YEARS LATER
Rook pushed off the capsule rim towards Iona. It was a stepping stone back to Moth.
THUMP


IONA
Elbow! Knee! Breathe! Got you! Floor loses again!

ROOK
Next time we compete, I am choosing a seated sport.

PIP / YEARS LATER

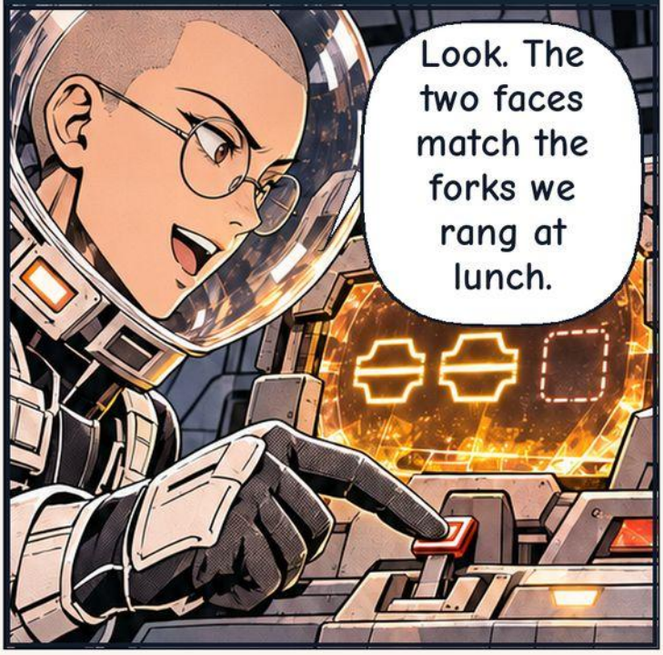
A diagnostic clamp: Tavi's bench tool for testing the core's two contacts separately.

TAVI

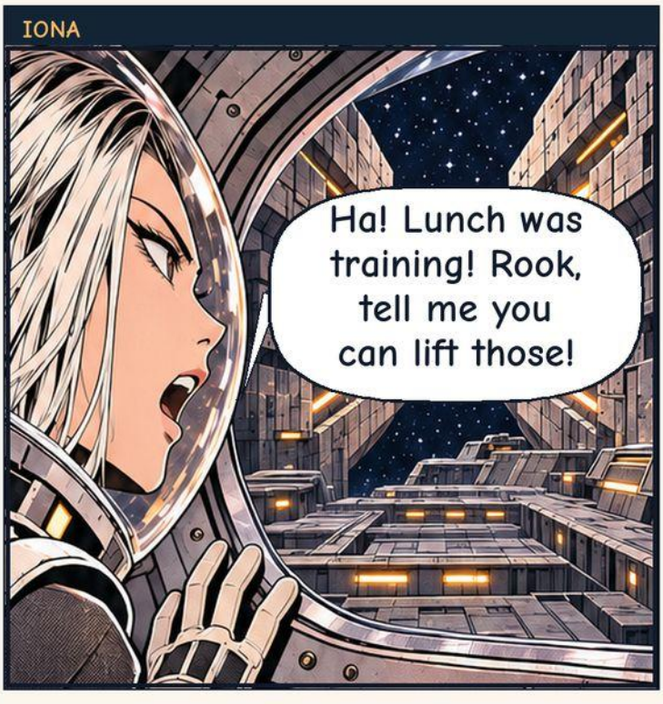
PIP / YEARS LATER

The ship's forks would ring like Tavi's lunch forks. The machine's contact faces were huge; Sera could tap one with each prong.

TAVI

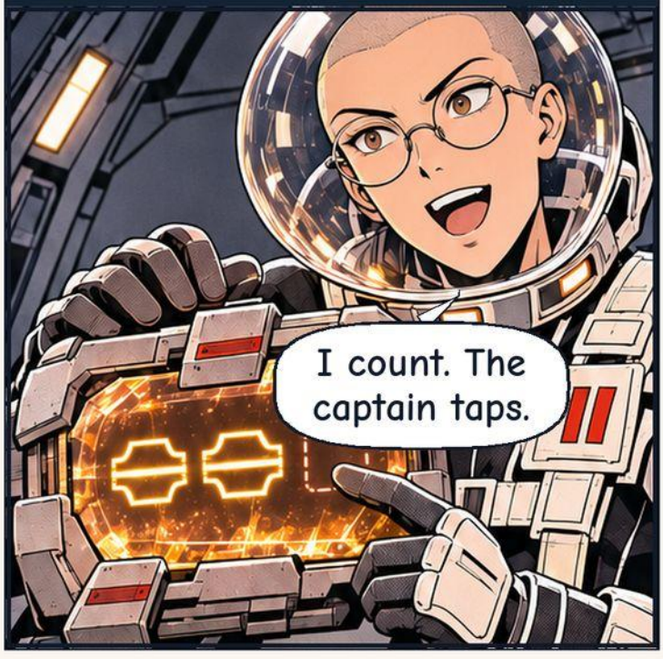


IONA



ROOK

TAVI



IONA

COMMS / IONA

Captain! Get those forks in! I'll get you out!

SERA

Show me your exit.

PIP / YEARS LATER

Moth sheltered below the contact faces; Needlewake stretched above it. Sera's hatch faced Moth's hatch across a short gap. Iona's line joined them.

IONA

Behind the lower rib! Rook's got us. One beat is enough!

THE WAY BACK

ROOK

One beat. Not two. You jump when I say.

SERA

Exit confirmed. Take positions.

PIP / LIVE

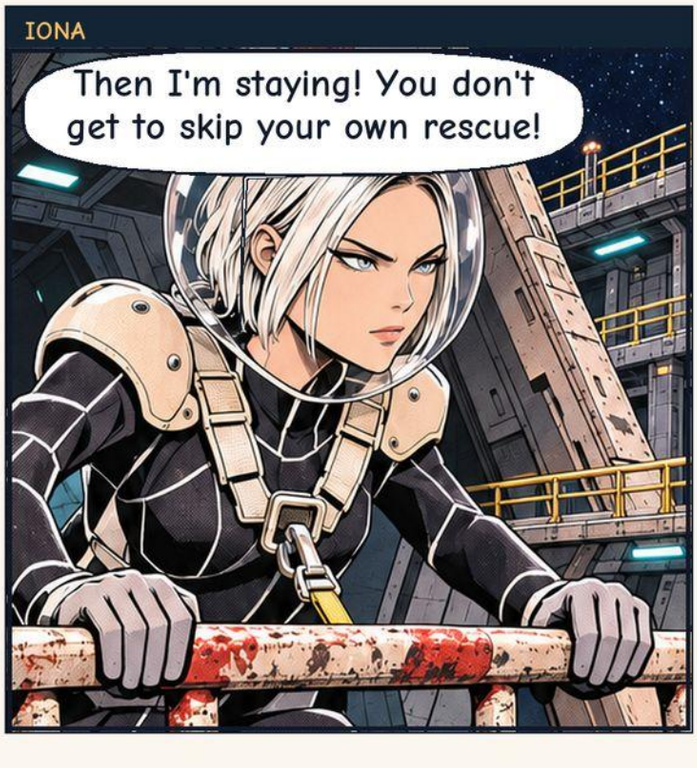
IONA

PIP / YEARS LATER

Both forks had to touch before Sera could lock the braces. After the answer, she would release them and jump.

SERA

IONA



SERA

PIP / YEARS LATER

Shrapnel punctured Moth's pressure pipe beside the hatch. Air was escaping. The last foam burst had to seal it.

IONA

TAVI

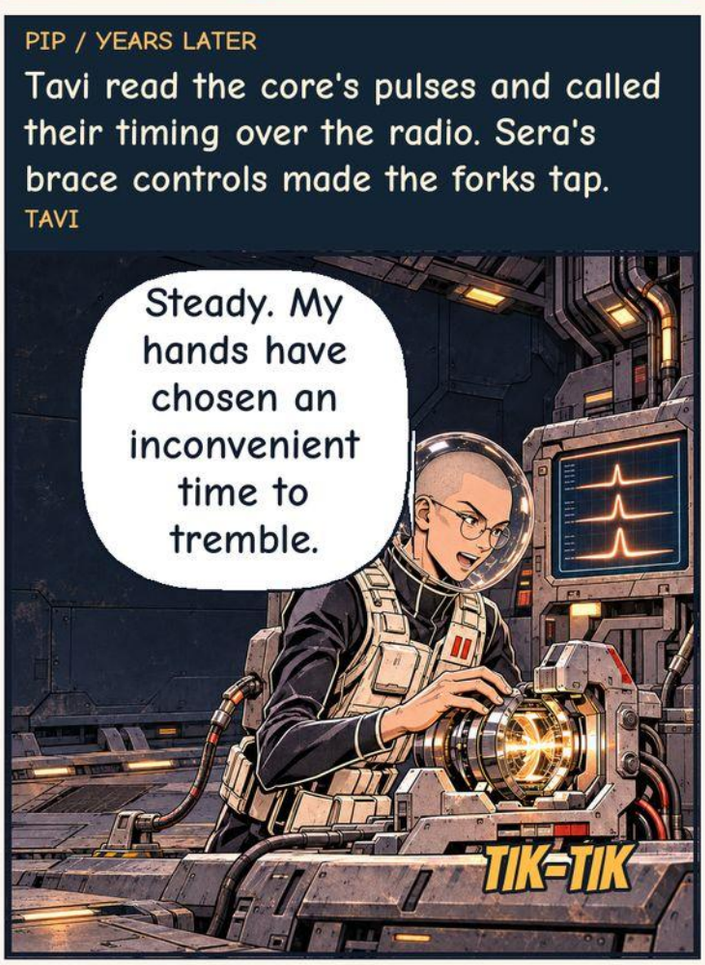
IONA

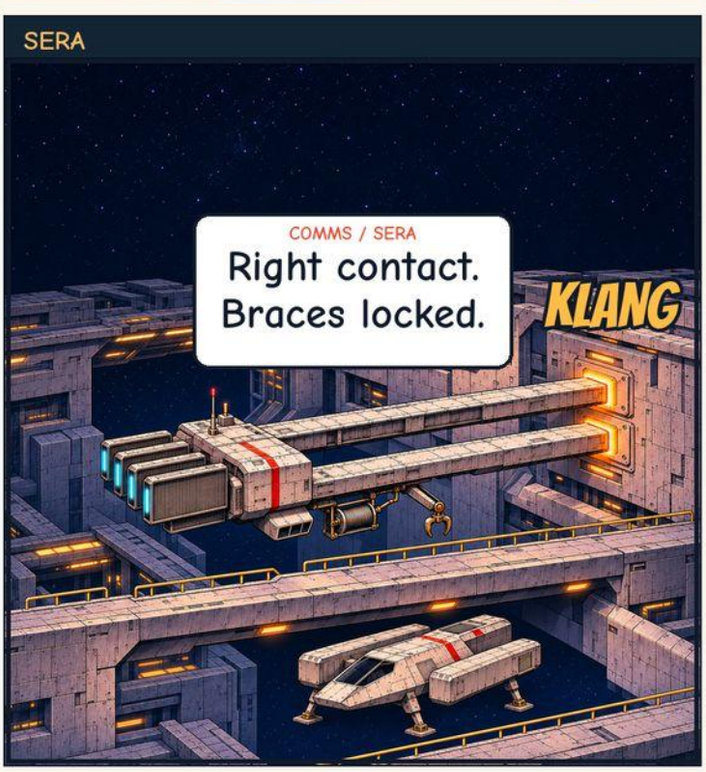
ROOK

SERA

PIP / YEARS LATER

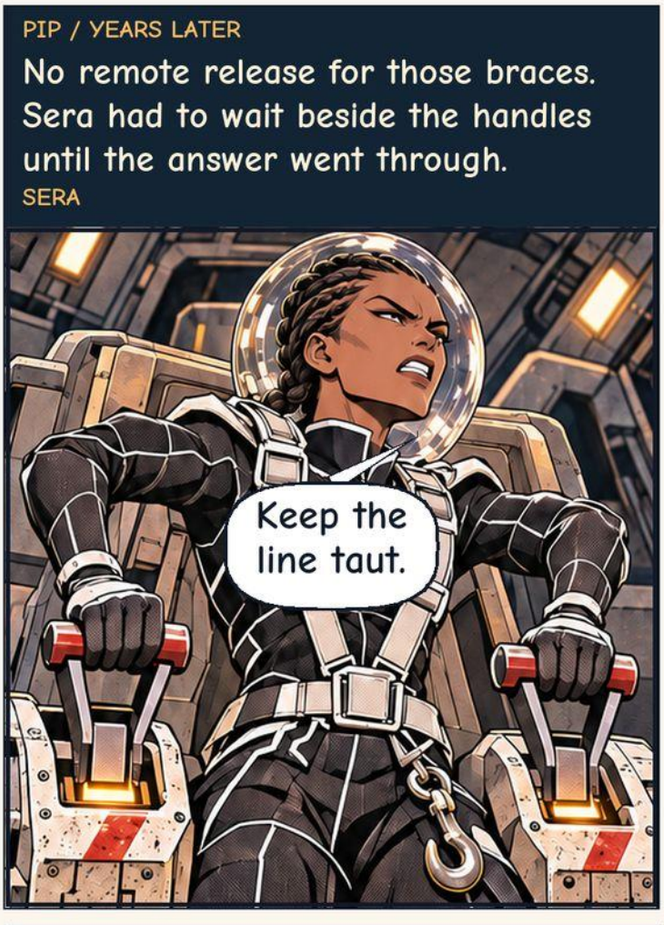
Tavi read the core's pulses and called their timing over the radio. Sera's brace controls made the forks tap.

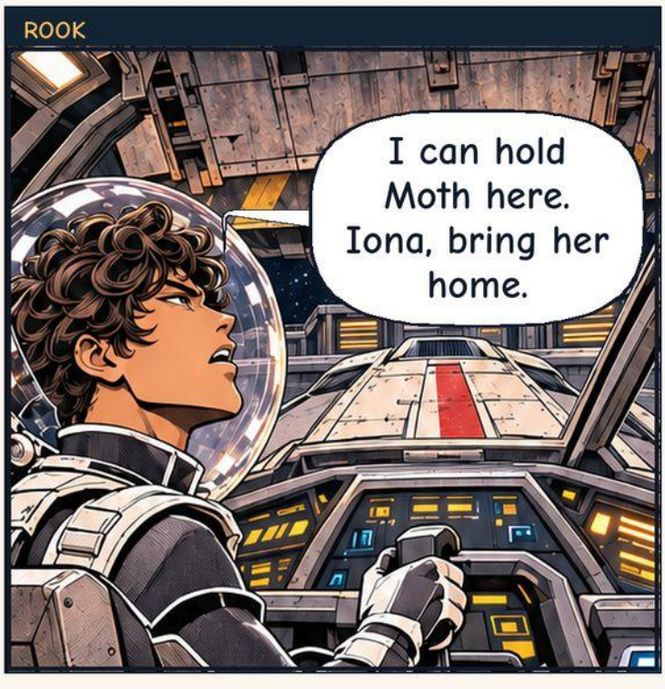


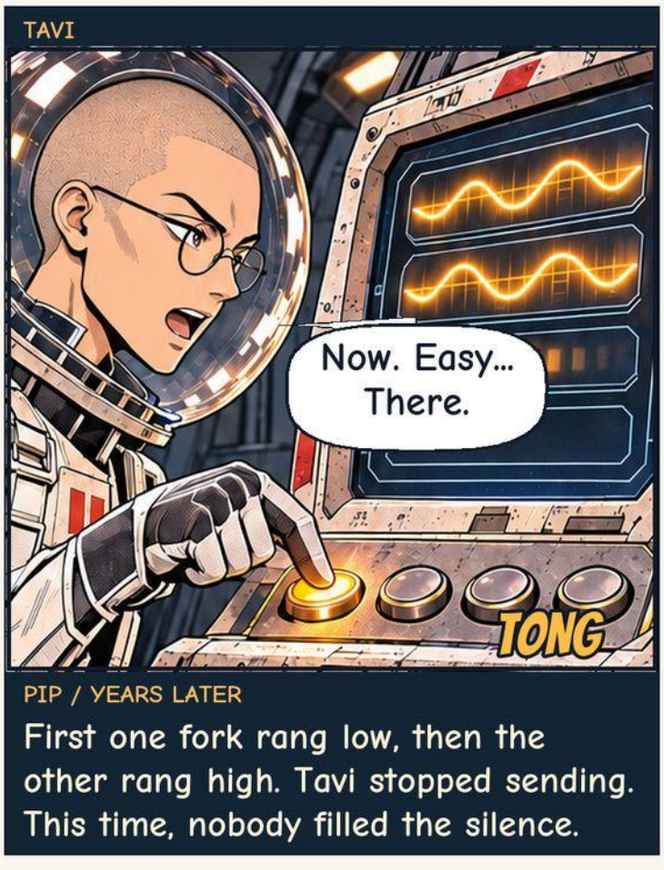


TAVI
Come on, old thing. We are trying very hard to be polite.
TOOOM

IONA
Your exit's ready, Captain! Try and make me leave!


PIP / YEARS LATER
No remote release for those braces. Sera had to wait beside the handles until the answer went through.
SERA
Keep the line taut.


ROOK
I can hold Moth here. Iona, bring her home.


TAVI
Now. Easy... There.
TONG
PIP / YEARS LATER
First one fork rang low, then the other rang high. Tavi stopped sending. This time, nobody filled the silence.

VWAAM
COMMS / ROOK
We just hit an ancient machine with a very expensive lullaby.

PIP / YEARS LATER

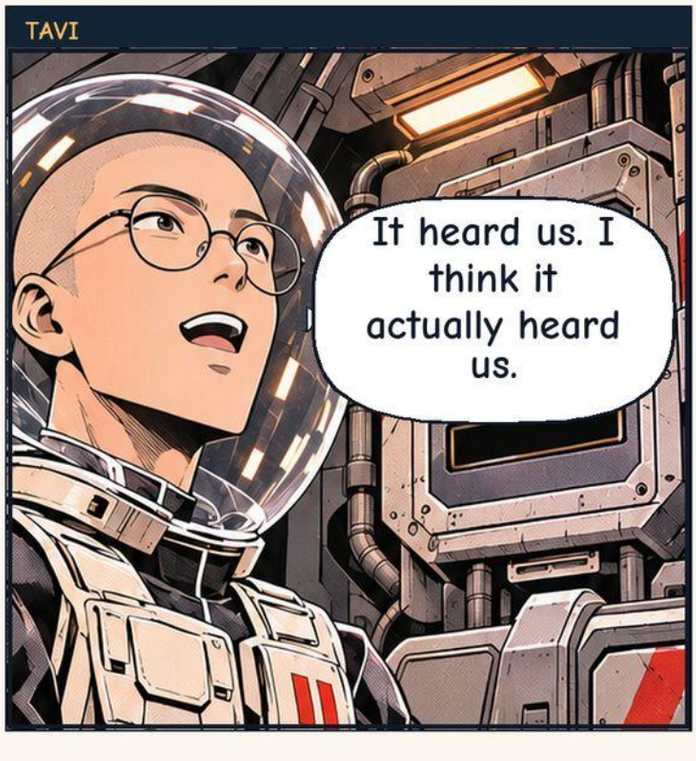
The plates paused. Sera released the braces and crossed from Needlewake's hatch to Moth. Iona caught her; Rook's remote controls would bring the empty ship after us.

SERA

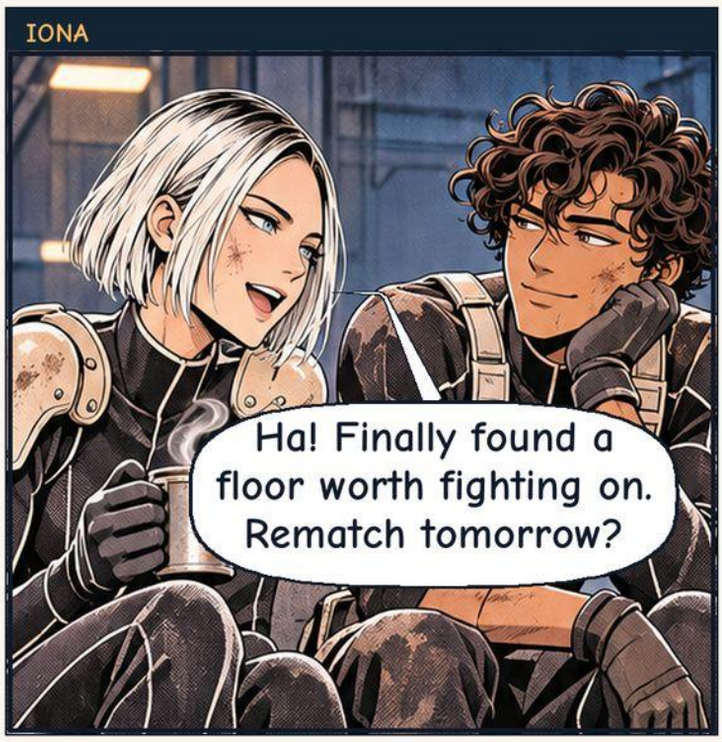
IONA

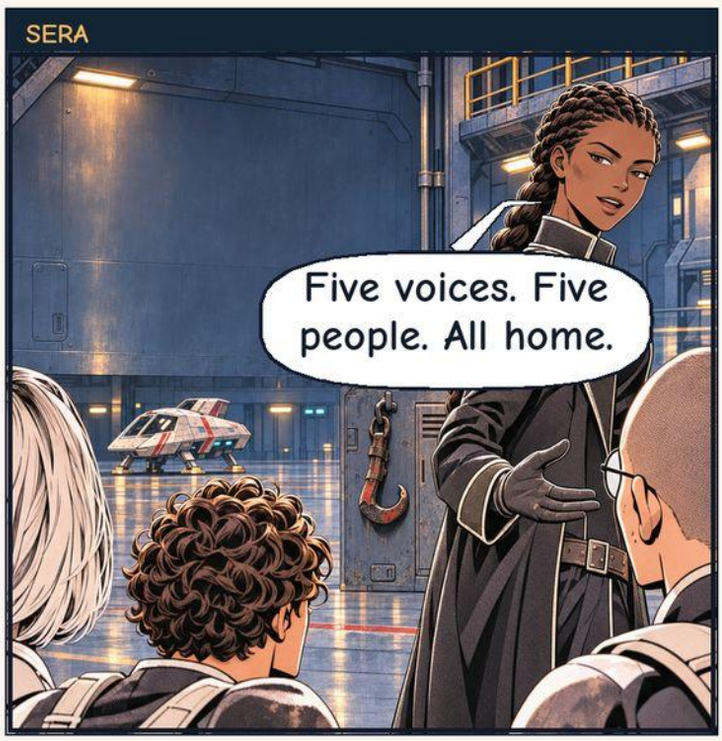
ROOK

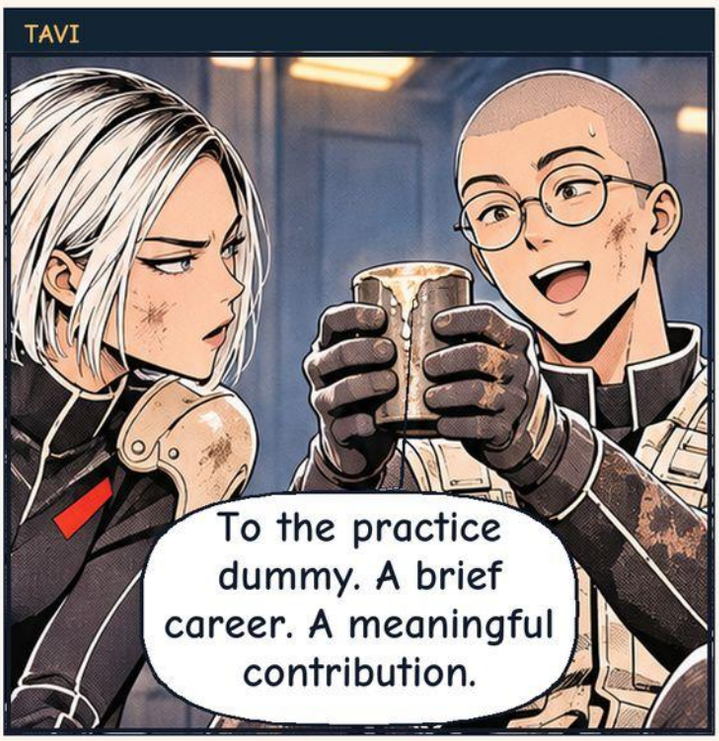
TAVI



ROOK
You used a capsule to catch me. That was cheating.


IONA
Ha! Finally found a floor worth fighting on. Rematch tomorrow?


SERA
Five voices. Five people. All home.

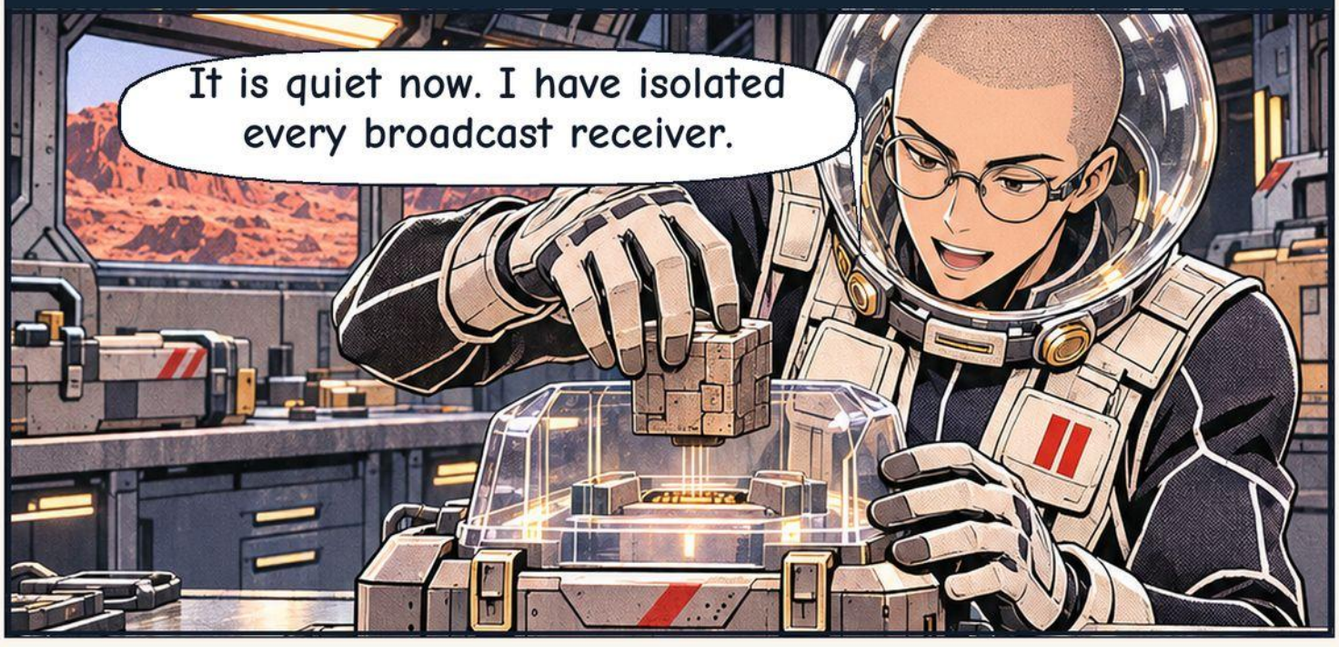

TAVI
To the practice dummy. A brief career. A meaningful contribution.

BEAM
FV
Our cadets have defeated gravity through outstanding personal commitment!
ROOK
Finally. An accurate assessment of my natural leadership qualities.
ROOK
That is heavier than the natural leadership qualities advertised.
IONA
Elbow! Knee! Breathe! Come on, hero! Beat the medal!
BEAM
FV
Another tactical hug! The heroes are embracing their achievements.

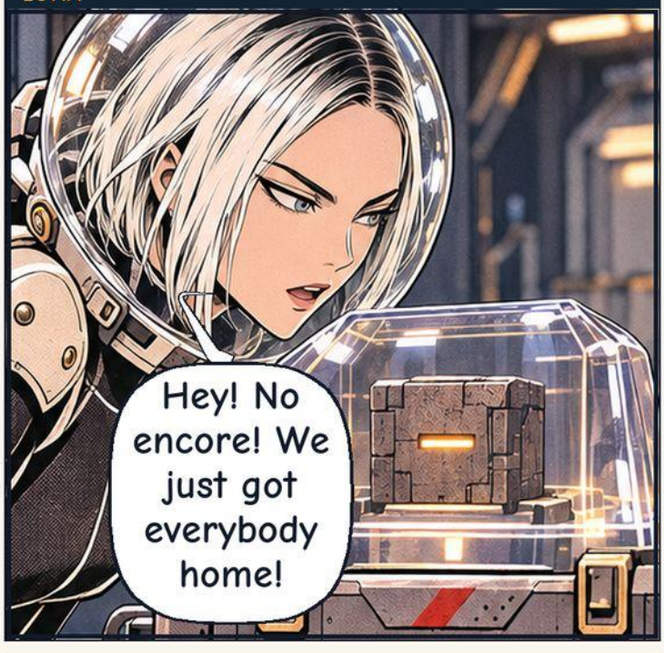
PIP / YEARS LATER

A receiver picks up signals. Tavi blocked incoming radio, but the core still had an outgoing signal.

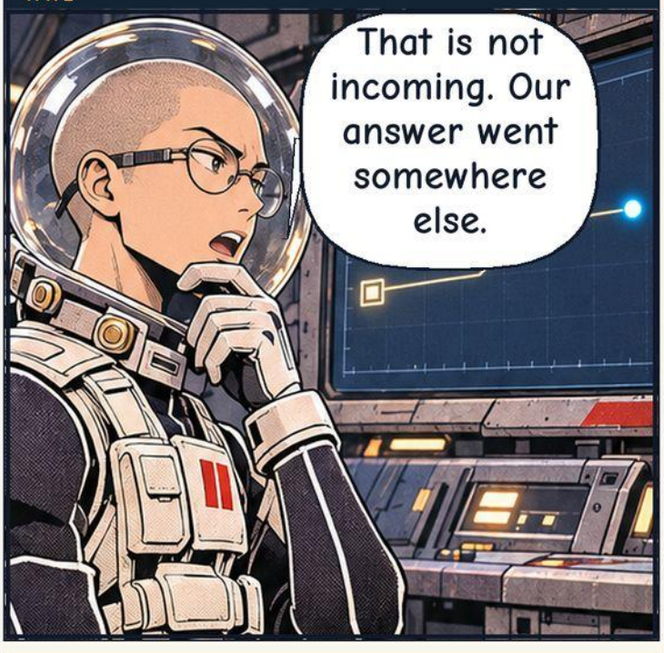
TAVI



IONA



TAVI

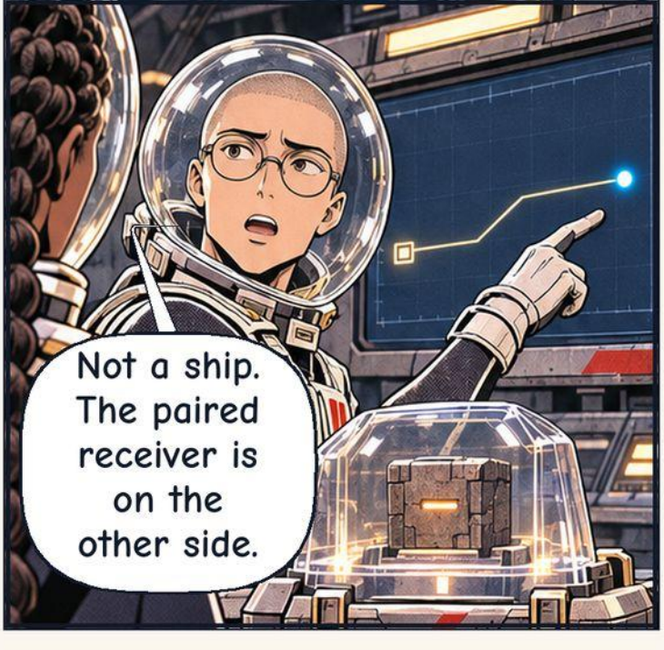


SERA

PIP / YEARS LATER

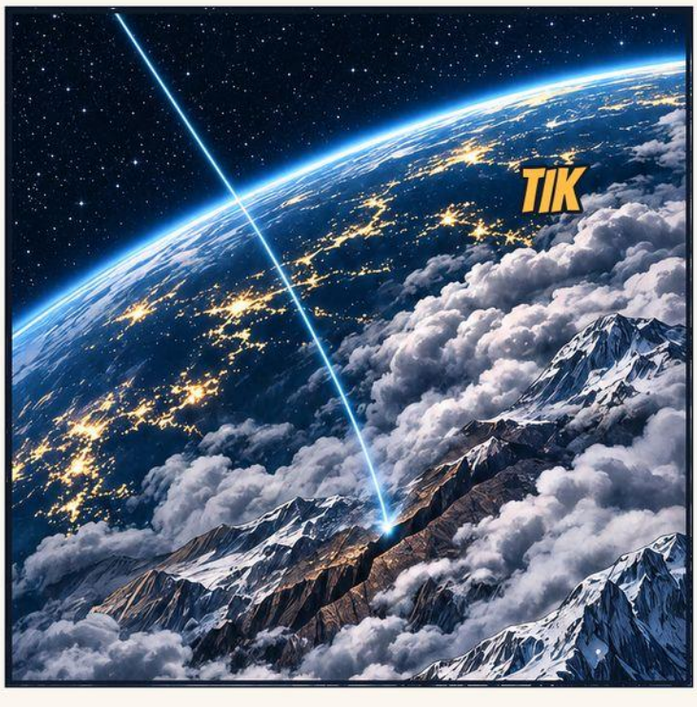
The core reported movement at its paired receiver. Tavi's tracker gave the bearing: Earth. No picture, no voice.

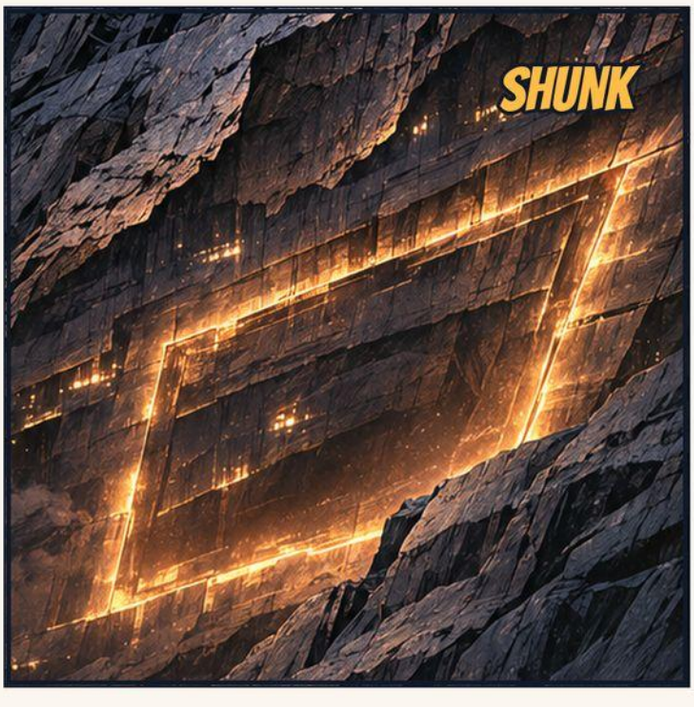
TAVI

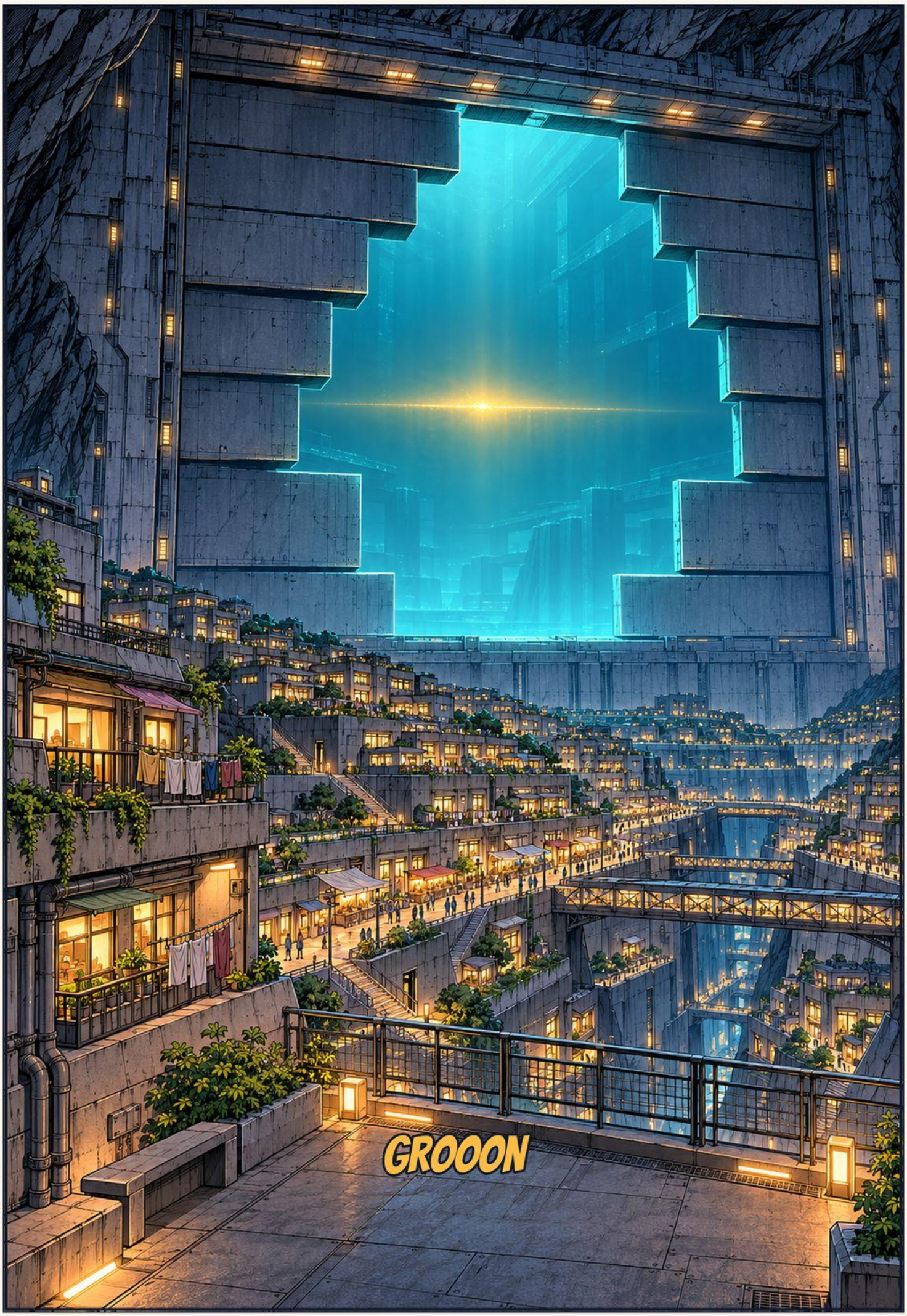


PIP / YEARS LATER

We'd brought everyone home. Our answer had reached Earth, and something there was opening. We didn't know what.






GROOON